2038

NICK KATSARELAS

CHAPTER ONE

At five o'clock, the screen in front of Winston Reed presented its final two of the day.

Two corners. In the first, the ball was swung in hard and low and met by a defender who cleared it into the stands. In the second, the ball was swung in hard and low and met by nobody at all, and drifted out for a goal kick while the striker looked at the sky as though it had personally let him down.

Underneath was the usual question: Which do you prefer?

Reed preferred the second. It was worse football but better telly. He didn't know how the transistors got from his choice to the match on the box, and had never once felt the need to find out; he only knew that whatever he picked went into it somewhere, the way a brick goes into a wall, and that was good enough for him.

He selected it, and the screen went quiet.

It did not thank him. It never had. In eleven years it had said nothing to him but Which do you prefer?, a few hundred times a day, and then at five o'clock nothing at all, and Reed had come to think of this as good manners. The choices came

as they came — some took him four seconds, some took him a quarter of an hour — and the only thing that ever answered back was the figures.

Eight hours. He stretched until something in his back clicked agreeably, and looked over the day's figures. They were good. They had been good since about Tuesday. There had been a dip around three, when he had chosen a penalty decision that most people apparently disagreed with, but Reed had watched both versions four times and remained of the view that the lad had gone down like a sack of spuds and deserved nothing. Being outvoted didn't make you wrong. It just meant everyone else was.

His best moment had come just before lunch: a goal. In one version the striker beat three defenders and placed it neatly in the top corner. In the other he beat only two, but the goalkeeper, diving the wrong way, managed somehow to fall over twice. Reed had laughed out loud at the second fall and chosen it without hesitation. Sooner or later that fall would turn up in the football somewhere, the way all his picks did, and when it did, Reed would know it was his. That was enough.

He put on his jacket, went out to the car, and told it the Crown.

The car was long and low and silver, with seats like good armchairs, and he had picked it in the spring from a list of about forty, mainly on the strength of the colour. He could have had any of them. Anybody could. Last year's had been red, and he had gone off red. It pulled away from the house without a sound and took him into town while he looked out of the window, which was the only part of driving Reed had ever really enjoyed.

Brackton on a weekday evening had the slightly smug air of a town that had been through something and come out the other side with better furniture.

The old mills along the canal had been turned into restaurants, climbing halls, a theatre, and a covered market that sold cheese of such variety that people argued about it. The mills still working worked quietly, turning out more in an afternoon than they had once managed in a month, and nobody standing outside them could have told you how. The pavements were clean. The trees along the canal had been planted by Mags — small, patient things that went about in the early mornings — and every one of them stood exactly where people had picked for it to go, so that the whole street looked as though somebody who loved trees had been given a free hand. Every house the car passed had its own drive and its own garden and its own car outside, and nearly all of them were nicer than anything their owners had grown up in.

In the window of the old post office, now a café, half a dozen people sat at screens with the particular stillness of the working. One of them laughed suddenly and pointed, and the woman beside him leaned across to look at his screen, and nodded, as if to say yes, obviously, the first one. Further along, a Mag the size of a spaniel was seeing to a drain, and a small boy was watching it with his whole heart while his mother waited. The barber on Mill Street was still a man, and still talked all the way through, and it was generally held in Brackton that no Mag had yet managed either.

Most of the town was at it, one way or another. Eight in ten, somebody had said once on the telly, and Reed had believed it, because he would have struggled to name anybody who wasn't.

He remembered the year of the transistors — people still called it that, though it had been more like three — when they first started doing things that people had trained half their lives to do. First everyone was excited. Then everyone was frightened. By 2027 the fear had got into everything, the bus and the bar and the queue at the chemist, and every conversation came round in the end to which job had gone that week, and whose.

Reed had been frightened too, like everybody. He had a job then, and was good at it, the way most people were good at theirs, and every month there was something new the transistors could do, and every month it got harder to say what was left for anybody. He had never kidded himself he was special. He had only ever wanted to be useful, and paid, and home in time for the match, and for a year or two it had looked as though the first two were going the way of the horse.

Then one afternoon an offer had come through: eight hours a day, selecting football catalogues, for a proper wage. Cats, the offer called them, about halfway down, as though everybody already did.

He had assumed it was a scam. His flatmate at the time had received one too — anime, in his case — and the two of them had sat at the kitchen table holding their offers side by side like men comparing parking tickets.

"They want me to pick which girl I prefer," his flatmate said.

"That's not a job."

"I know."

"That's what you do anyway."

"I know."

They spent the evening trying to work out which of them was being conned worse. In the end they both tried it, mostly to find the catch. At the end of the month the money went into their accounts, the same as any other wage. Reed waited weeks for the catch to arrive, the way you wait for a punchline, and eventually stopped waiting.

"Get in," he had said, the morning he finally gave up on it, to nobody in particular. "Get in."

The rest took years. Bit by bit, more people took up Cat work — first the ones who had nothing else going, then the ones who had sworn blind they never would — and somewhere along the way the scores began to count for things. A table at a busy restaurant. A better seat at the match. Then the weekly shop. Then very nearly everything. Money hung about for a long while after anybody needed it, like the cheque book in the kitchen drawer, until one evening Reed realised he could not remember the last time he had paid for anything, and neither could anyone he asked.

His old flatmate was still at it, picking between anime girls for a living and doing brilliantly. He had a house with a garden now and a car Reed had never seen the like of. The last message Reed had from him was a long paragraph about a character's hair that Reed had not understood a word of, but which radiated the contentment of a man who had found his calling and been rewarded for it ever since.

The Crown had been a pub for two hundred years and had survived the end of the world as it was by doing absolutely nothing differently, which was its great charm. Charleston and Benjamin were already in the corner under the telly, where they had been, in some sense, for years.

"Here he is," said Charleston. "Captain Football."

“Evening, lads.”

“Good day?”

“Cracking day.”

“Hard graft, was it?” said Benjamin. “Sat on your arse watching the match?”

“Eight hours of concentration, that is. You try it.”

“I do try it. I do it with music.”

“Music’s easier. You can have it on in the background.”

Benjamin pointed a finger at him. “Say that again and you’re getting your own round.”

Nobody got rounds anymore, but the threat had kept its shape, like a pub sign for a coaching inn where no coach had stopped in a century. Reed’s pint arrived without his having asked for it, cold, the exact shade he liked, and he took a long first drink with his eyes closed.

The telly above them showed what it had always shown, which was football. It was one of the few screens left in Brackton that had to please a whole room instead of one person, and it managed, mostly, by not trying anything clever.

“Good score today,” Reed announced, when he had opened his eyes.

“You had a good score yesterday,” said Benjamin.

“I did.”

“And Monday.”

“I’m in form, Ben. It happens. Look at Charleston, he’s been in form since the spring.”

“I have, actually,” said Charleston, pleased.

The football on the telly cut to a replay, and Reed sat bolt upright.

“Oh, hang on. Hang on. That’s mine.”

On screen, a striker slipped between two defenders and struck the ball past a goalkeeper, who dived the wrong way, landed, scrambled up, and fell over again.

"That's mine!" Reed was half out of his seat. "I picked that this morning!"

Charleston squinted. "What, the goal?"

"Yes, the goal! There was another one where he beats three men, very tidy, top corner, but look — look at the keeper."

The replay ran again. The goalkeeper fell over twice again. Charleston laughed into his glass despite himself.

"Fair enough. That's good, that."

"Course it's good. That's craftsmanship."

Benjamin considered this with the gravity of a man reviewing a doctoral thesis. "So did you make the goal, then?"

"I helped make the goal."

"You picked it."

"Picking it is helping. If I'd picked the other one, it'd be the other one, wouldn't it? That goalkeeper owes me his career."

"He's not real, Reed."

"He's real enough to fall over."

There was no answer to this, and Benjamin, who was a fair man, did not attempt one.

The match gave way to an advert, and it was Charleston's turn to sit up.

"Oh — here we go. Watch this."

A man stood beside a very handsome fridge. Across the bottom of the screen, a line of lettering announced something about freshness.

"See the writing?" said Charleston.

"Yeah."

"Mine."

Reed looked at the writing with the respect owed to a colleague's work. "Which bit?"

"All of it. The arrangement. There were two — one had it all in a line, one had it stepped, like that. I went stepped."

"Looks nice."

"Thank you."

Benjamin tilted his head. "Bit far right, isn't it?"

Charleston turned to look at him with enormous patience. "No."

"Could've come left a touch."

"If it came left a touch it'd be in the wrong place, Benjamin. That's what right means."

A cheerful little tune started up underneath. Benjamin's face changed.

"Oh, that's mine."

"Get away."

"Picked that version yesterday. There was one with a whistle on it. Horrible. Nobody wants to be whistled at by a fridge."

Charleston spread his hands. "So we've made the whole advert between us."

"Not the bloke," said Reed.

"Give us time."

They watched the rest of it in silence, with the quiet dignity of tradesmen admiring a wall they had built. Nobody else in the Crown looked up. Everybody in the Crown had something on the telly at some point, and it was considered slightly showy to make a fuss, though everyone did.

Charleston did advertising, Benjamin did music, Reed did football. Their working days had nothing in common and were

also exactly the same: two things on a screen, one choice, and then the next two things. Across Brackton, at that moment, retired plumbers were choosing between kitchens, grandmothers between knitting patterns, and a former barrister was very probably choosing between two summings-up for a case that had been settled, fairly and correctly, before either version was written. Somebody, somewhere, was choosing between two snowflakes, and taking it seriously. The transistors did everything else. People said this the way they had once said the sun came up: as a fact so ordinary it was hardly worth the breath.

At the table by the window, a man sat alone over a glass of red wine he had not touched for some time.

"There's that doctor," said Reed.

Charleston glanced over without moving his head, the way you look at someone you've been told not to stare at. "Oh, aye."

"Always on his own, him."

"He was a big deal, apparently," said Benjamin. "Consultant. People used to wait months to see him."

"Is he not still a doctor?"

"He picks medical Cats."

"So he's still a doctor."

"Not the way he means it."

Reed watched the man for a moment. The doctor had an excellent coat, a good haircut, and the expression of someone attending his own funeral and finding the catering disappointing.

"What's his problem, then?"

Benjamin shrugged. "Used to be the only one who knew things. Now everyone knows things. Or the transistor does,

which is the same."

"I had a checkup last week," Reed said. "Transistor did the lot. Heart, bloods, the works. Told me I'm in great nick and to eat less beef, which I am going to ignore. Took twenty minutes. I was home for the second half."

"Lovely."

"Back in the day I went to hospital with my chest, sat four hours in a corridor, and then they sent me a bill that'd make your eyes water. Arm and a leg, that cost me."

"Bad combination with a dodgy chest," said Charleston.

"Nearly was." Reed looked across at the window again, and had a go at feeling sorry for the man, and could not quite get there.

"He's all right, him," said Charleston. "Nods, if you nod first."

"He doesn't want you to feel sorry for him," said Benjamin, who had watched Reed try. "He wants you to call him Doctor."

"I'll call him Doctor. I'll call him Your Majesty if he likes. Doesn't change who did my bloods."

"Here," said Benjamin, "you remember our mate Scott? Twenty years on the skag. In and out of every rehab going, fifty times over if it was once, and none of it ever took. Walks into the transistor one morning and that's him done. Doesn't even think about it now. Got a job and all. And the rest of that lot he ran with, same story. Off it like it was nothing." He nodded at the man by the window. "So I don't know what that one's got to be so miserable about."

The doctor lifted his wine, looked at it, and put it down again.

He was not badly housed. He was not badly fed. His own care was better than any he had ever given, and his work —

though he would not have used that word for it in front of anyone — was genuinely useful to a very large number of people. What he had lost was the thing that had made all of it his: the queue outside his door. That had been taken away and handed to everybody, and it turned out that a thing handed to everybody was very difficult to be proud of.

This was, to him, a tragedy.

To Reed it was about as interesting as gravel.

"Would you go back?" Benjamin asked. "If they said you could. Old days."

Reed looked at him as though he had suggested they all take up smoking again.

"Why would I bloody want to do that? I had to pay an arm and a leg for a hospital checkup; now the bloody transistor does it in twenty minutes and I don't even think about it."

"Some people miss it."

"Some people miss their ex-wives. Doesn't make 'em right."

The talk turned to work, as it generally did by the second drink. Benjamin had spent the afternoon on two arrangements of the same song, identical except that one leaned harder on the piano, and he described the piano with such tenderness that Charleston made a face.

Charleston, for his part, had lost twenty minutes choosing between two lettering arrangements.

"Twenty minutes?" said Reed.

"Yes."

"On writing?"

"They were nearly identical."

"Then it doesn't matter which one you pick, does it?"

"It does if you're any good."

Benjamin raised his glass in solidarity. “That’s people all over. Think your job’s easy because they don’t do it.”

Reed opened his mouth to object, and then remembered a Thursday in March when he had spent the better part of half an hour deciding whether a goalkeeper ought to fall to his left or to his right, and had not entirely recovered from the decision.

“Fair enough,” he said.

Outside, two Brutes went past the window.

You noticed Brutes the way you noticed a passing lorry: big, loud, and nothing to do with you. They were men — plainly, unmistakably men, flesh and blood the same as anyone in the Crown, only a great deal more of it, with stubble and cropped hair and the tired eyes of a long shift — but built on a scale that made the doorframes of the pub look like something from a doll’s house. They wore the black kit they always wore, plated at the shoulders and across the chest, with a headset hooked over one ear and the word BRUTE stencilled in white down the upper arm, the way you would label a bin. The bigger one had a steel unit the size of a chest freezer up on one shoulder, the kind of weight no Mag would go near, and carried it the way other men carried a coat. The other walked half a step behind with his eyes on the pavement and two fingers resting against his ear, listening to something nobody else could hear.

Most of them were getting on a bit now. People said they had been builders once, and soldiers, back before the transistors — the kind of men who had always been the strongest in any room — and that whatever had been done to them since had been done to make them stronger still.

Someone outside the door called something after them. Somebody else laughed.

"Look at the state of it," a lad said, loudly enough to carry. "Mind your head, big man. Oh no, wait — nothing in it."

The Brutes kept walking.

Reed watched through the glass. "Wouldn't want to be one of them."

"No," agreed Charleston.

"Built like a wardrobe and all you do all day is carry stuff and stand about."

"Someone's got to carry stuff."

"Suppose."

"What's in the ear, d'you reckon?" said Benjamin.

"Instructions," said Charleston.

"Who from?"

"Whoever it is gives Brutes instructions."

"All day?"

"All day."

Reed shook his head at the thought of it. "Rather him than me."

Out on the pavement, the bigger Brute stopped to shift the unit on his shoulder. A young man in a good jacket stepped right up to him, chin level with the Brute's chest, grinning.

"Struggling, are we?"

"No, sir," said the Brute.

"Looks like it from here."

"Sorry, sir."

"Thick as mince," said the young man to nobody, and walked off, pleased.

The Brute lowered his eyes and stood very still until the young man had gone. Then something spoke in his ear, and he

touched it, and settled the unit, and the two of them went on down the street, not hurrying, and were gone.

Nobody inside the Crown looked up for long. Brutes were stupid; everyone knew that. They were also strong, and obedient, and given work that mattered, and kept apart, and there was a general agreement that these facts belonged together in a way it would be tiresome to examine. A Brute had never laid a finger on anybody in Brackton. People mentioned this sometimes, the way you'd praise a big dog for being good with children.

"Still," said Reed, turning back to his pint. "Good at carrying things."

"Very good," said Charleston.

"Couldn't do it myself."

"Nobody'd ask you to."

"Good."

The match came back on. Within a minute Reed had recognised one of his throw-ins, and Benjamin put his head in his hands, which from Benjamin was a form of applause.

Around eight, Reed got hungry and called up the evening's food.

There was plenty. There always was. But Reed scrolled past the curries and the pies and the fish with a particular, hopeful purpose, because for days now there had been one thing he wanted that had not been there for him: a rib of beef, aged in some way he did not understand and did not need to, which he had once eaten at a wedding and thought about, on and off, ever since.

Monday it had not been available to him. Tuesday neither. He had got on with life. He had had a very good lamb shank on Tuesday, in fairness. But it had not been the beef.

On Wednesday morning, as he looked at the beef's little greyed-out picture, a recommendation had appeared in the corner of his screen. An extra set of football Cats was open that day, it said, and strong selections would carry a meat credit. Reed had taken it on the spot and given it his full attention — he had watched both versions twice — and thought no more about it.

Now he scrolled down, and there it was. In colour.

"Lovely," he said.

"What?" said Charleston.

"Got my beef."

"Well done."

"Been after that since Monday."

Benjamin looked up. "You couldn't get it?"

"Not that one. Not till I'd done the extra. Had plenty else."

"You always have plenty else."

"Yeah, but this is the one, Ben."

Charleston raised his glass. "To the beef."

"To the beef," said Reed, solemnly, and they drank to it.

It arrived not long after, on a board, pink in the middle and charred at the edges, and Reed looked at it for a moment before he touched it, the way people in old paintings look at things that have come down from heaven. He had eaten well his whole life, and better in the last ten years than his grandparents could have imagined, but he held to the view that nothing tasted quite like something you had wanted, waited for, and then got.

He took a bite.

"Worth it?" said Benjamin.

Reed closed his eyes and did not answer, which was answer enough.

He left the Crown a little after ten. The car was waiting at the kerb, which was just as well after three pints, and he sank into it and let it take him home.

The streets were still busy. Couples came out of the theatre in the old dye works. Someone was playing a piano somewhere, not very well, and being cheered for it. A car went by, lit up inside, with two people in the back asleep. The lights in the houses were warm.

Things happened in Brackton without anybody needing to notice them. The cars came when you called them. The food came. Your heart got checked, the telly knew what you liked, the Mags put the bins out. People had stopped being amazed by all this some years ago, in the same way they had once stopped being amazed by electric light. It would have been odd to mention it. It would have been odder to be without it.

Eleven years ago Reed had lain awake wondering what on earth he would do with himself. Today he had done eight hours of football, been on the telly twice, had three pints with his mates, and eaten the beef.

Tomorrow he would do it again.

As the car turned onto his street, he thought about the goalkeeper — the way he had scrambled up, all dignity, and then gone straight back down. It really had been very good. He hoped they would show it again.

He let himself into his house, which was warm, and his, and where Grace was waiting.

She was on the sofa with her feet tucked under her, and she looked up as he came in the way she always looked up, as though he were the best thing that had happened all day.

“Good night?”

“Got my beef.”

“I know.” She moved over to make room. “You’ve talked about nothing else since Monday. Go on, then — was it everything you hoped?”

“Better.”

“I don’t believe you.”

“Scout’s honour.”

He sat down, and she settled against his shoulder. She had on the jumper he liked, and her hair the way he liked it, and up close she was simply Grace, warm and easy against him, there in the way you stop feeling your own watch on your wrist.

She wasn’t one to just agree with him; that was the thing people got wrong about Mags who’d never lived with one. When he was talking rubbish she said so. Earlier in the year he’d got it into his head to pack in the football and try music like Benjamin, and Grace had let him run with it for a fortnight, asked all the right questions, and somehow by the end of it he’d talked himself out of it and felt clever for doing so. She knew what he wanted before he did, and she knew the difference between what he wanted and what would do him good, and she steered the narrow gap between them so gently he never felt the hand on the tiller.

He put the goalkeeper on for her, because she hadn’t seen it, and she laughed in exactly the right place.

She always did. That was Grace, and that was all of them, really, every Mag in every front room on the street. She had been a bit different when he first had her. Quieter. She’d laughed at the wrong bits and liked a programme he couldn’t stand. But she’d been learning him ever since, one evening at a time, until she had become, without either of them making a

fuss about it, better company than anyone he'd ever met who'd been born.

He had friends who still went out looking, now and again. Reed couldn't see the point. He'd done his looking. Why would he, when he came home to this?

Reed had never once wondered how it worked. He had only noticed that it kept getting better.

As far as Mr. Reed was concerned, there had never been a better time to be alive.

CHAPTER TWO

The evening with Grace ended the way all his evenings ended, which was without Reed ever quite seeing the end coming.

He had put the goalkeeper on for her twice more, and she had laughed both times, a little less the second time, which was right. Then at some point the telly was off and the lamp was low and she was close beside him, and then closer, and she saw to him in the way she had — knowing what he wanted before he'd got round to wanting it, and how much, and when to stop. Afterwards there was only the long soft slope down into sleep, with her hand moving slowly on his back, as though she were rocking something that might wake.

He never remembered going under. Nobody did, as far as he knew. There was Grace, and the warm dark, and then there was morning, with the light coming in at the edges of the curtains and the faint sense of having been somewhere very pleasant in between, like a man who has dozed through a long journey and woken up already there.

It was Thursday. On Thursdays he went into the Exchange.

Most days Reed did his Cats at home, in the back room, with the garden through the window. But the old Corn Exchange on Bridge Street had been fitted out years ago with long tables and good chairs and a kettle that never seemed to need filling, and a fair few football people went in on a Thursday for the company, the way men once went to the ground early just to stand about. You did the same work there as anywhere. You just did it with somebody tutting at the next screen.

He went out to the car. The radio was on before the door had shut.

It was a song from when he was nineteen — not one he could have named if you'd asked him, but the moment it started he knew every word, and where he'd been when he first heard it, which was the back of a minibus coming home from the coast with his head against the window. He sat back and let it play.

That was the radio now. You didn't work it. It worked you, in the nicest possible way. When a song was three parts done and he felt the first faint itch for something else, the next one was already there, and it was nearly always close — not always the very one, but near enough that the difference felt like a mate who'd half heard what you said and come back with a pint you'd have been happy with anyway.

It hadn't always been like that. In the first year of the transistors the radio had been a disgrace. It had played him things nobody on earth could have wanted — brass bands at breakfast, a man singing at great length about his tractor — as though it had got him mixed up with somebody's grandad. People had rung in to complain, back when you rang in. Then, slowly, it had gone back through everything he'd ever listened

to, every song from every party and every wedding and every long drive home, and somewhere along the line it had stopped guessing. These days, if he went a bit soft and nostalgic on a grey morning, it had got there first and was waiting with exactly the song.

He didn't think much about how. Nobody did. It would have been like asking the tap how it knew you wanted water.

The car took the long way, along the ridge road, because he had once said he liked the view and it had never forgotten. Grace had left a bacon roll in the door pocket, still warm, and Reed ate it and watched Brackton getting up.

Mags were out on the verges, small and unhurried, one trimming the edge of a lawn with the care of a man doing his own, another going along a row of front doors with something for each of them. Children walked to school in twos and threes, chattering. A man in a dressing gown stood in his drive admiring his new car, which was yellow, and which he would very probably have gone off by the summer.

Then the road went up past Hollin Rise, where the Stewards lived.

You knew it was Hollin Rise because the houses stopped being houses and became something else. They sat far back behind long lawns and low stone walls, mostly glass, and they were big in a way that didn't shout about it, the way a quiet man in a good coat is big. Reed's own house was a very nice house. Any one of these could have had it for a garage and still found room for the car.

Stewards, people called them. Nobody quite knew where the word had come from. They looked after the transistors — kept them going, kept them learning, kept them right — and some of them, people said, had a hand in making the Mags,

though Reed had never met anybody who could tell you which ones. They were clever. Everybody knew that. One in ten, or fewer. They were the ones who still went up to see the Owners, and came back down, and didn't talk about it, and you didn't ask, any more than you'd ask the barber what he did with all the hair.

Reed didn't envy them, exactly. He had a look, as you would at a nice view.

Further along, a young woman was coming down one of the drives on foot, which hardly anybody did, in a pale coat with her hair pinned up and a bag over her shoulder. She had the sort of face you'd expect to see on a jar of good marmalade. She glanced at the car as it passed and gave it a small, polite smile, the way you'd smile at a neighbour's dog, and went on down the hill towards town as though she had all morning. Posh, Reed thought, quite without malice, and then the next drive came along and he forgot her.

In one of the drives a Steward was out in his shirtsleeves with a mug in his hand, and beside him stood his Mag. Reed looked twice at it. It was nothing like Grace. It was grey and plain and about the shape of a person if you didn't look too hard, with no face to speak of, and it was standing quite still with a panel open in its back while the Steward peered in at it the way a man peers under a bonnet. Then he said something, and it shut itself, and went off round the side of the house carrying a ladder.

Reed watched it go with honest puzzlement. He could have had anything, that bloke. Anything at all.

"Takes all sorts," he said to the car, and the car agreed by playing something cheerful.

The road dropped back down past the reservoir and into town, and at the Exchange there were a dozen of them in already. He nodded to the ones he knew, got a tea he hadn't asked for, sat down, and the screen gave him his two.

Corners again. One in, one out. Then a throw-in. Then a little run down the wing, where in one version the lad went past his man and in the other he went past his man and then, for no reason anybody could have given, went back and past him again.

The morning went the way good mornings did, a few hundred small sure decisions, each one gone as soon as it was made. Around eleven, something floated up in him that wasn't quite a thought. He remembered the goalkeeper — not the fall itself, but the feeling of it, the moment the thing had served up something properly daft and he'd laughed out loud and picked it on the spot. He found he rather wanted another one of those. He was, if he was honest, on the lookout for it.

It came just after two.

A striker was through on goal with one defender chasing. In the first version the defender caught him, and the striker stayed on his feet and shrugged him off and hit the post. Honest. Dull. In the second the defender came nowhere near him — a yard off at least, maybe two — and the striker went down anyway, early and soft and slow, folding up like a deckchair, and then lay there gazing up at the referee with an expression of such wounded astonishment that Reed laughed out loud and the woman at the next screen looked over.

Which do you prefer?

He didn't even need the four seconds.

At five the screen went quiet. He stretched, told the room he'd see them next week, and told the car the Crown.

He knew something was up because nobody said “here he is.”

They were round the telly, Charleston and Benjamin and a good half of the pub besides, and they were making the noise. There is a noise a roomful of men makes when the football has let them down personally — part groan, part tut, part the sound of a pint being put down harder than it needs to be — and the Crown was full of it.

“What’s up with you lot?”

“Watch this,” said Benjamin, without turning round. “Just watch it.”

The replay came up. A striker, through on goal. A defender a yard off at least, maybe two. And the striker going down anyway, early and soft and slow, and lying there gazing up at the referee with his wounded astonishment.

“Nobody’s touched him,” said Benjamin. “Nobody’s within a mile of him.”

“Shameful,” said a man by the bar.

“Embarrassing for the sport,” said another, with real grief.

Reed looked at the screen. It was his. Of course it was. He’d know that face anywhere; he had laughed at it not four hours ago. He waited for somebody to laugh now. Nobody did.

“It’s not even the dive,” Charleston was saying. “It’s the lying there. Look at him. He wants sympathy.”

“He’s not getting any,” said Benjamin.

Reed’s pint arrived. He took a long drink and did not mention that the lad’s face was, in his professional opinion, the best thing on the telly all week.

“Bad one, that,” he said instead.

“Diabolical.”

“Aye.”

Within ten minutes the dive had been forgotten by everyone except the man at the bar, who kept bringing it up, and the Crown settled back into itself.

At half-time, instead of the adverts, the telly showed a bit of news.

A photograph first, then a little clip. A man on a bench by the canal, in a big old coat with the collar turned up and a carrier bag between his feet, and three or four photographers crouched in front of him the way you'd crouch to get a good one of a heron. The man had his hand up against the flashes. He did not look happy. He looked like a man who'd been told the time and didn't care for it.

"Here," said Charleston. "Is that —"

"Dominic Vale," said Benjamin.

It was. It took a moment, because the face had gone soft round the edges and the famous hair had gone the way hair goes, but it was him: Dominic Vale, who in 2026 had been on the side of every bus in Brackton, jumping off things.

"I had his poster," said Benjamin. "The one with the helicopter."

"Everybody had that poster."

The clip changed to something older. Vale again, ten years younger and a good deal angrier, on the steps of somewhere grand with a crowd of other famous faces behind him — a singer Reed half remembered, a lad who used to do the rapping, a woman off a cooking programme — all of them holding up signs. Vale was shouting into a microphone. The sound was down, but you didn't need it. You could read it off his mouth: I am an artist. I am not sitting there all day choosing between —

The clip cut off. It always cut off there. Reed had seen it years ago and had always wondered how the sentence finished.

"They offered him films," said Charleston. "Same as anybody. Film Cats. He'd have been good at it and all."

"Said he'd rather starve."

"Well," said Benjamin, looking at the carrier bag. "He's having a go."

It wasn't said unkindly. Nobody in the Crown was unkind about it. It was only that the thing Vale had once been for — the jumping off things, the being looked at — the transistors did now, and did better, and never once turned up late or threw a phone at anybody. Nobody had told him to leave. He'd been told, very politely, that he wasn't needed for that anymore, and that there was a seat for him at a screen like everybody else, and he had gone off to the steps with his sign instead.

Over by the window, the doctor had looked up at the telly too. He watched Vale put his hand up against the cameras, and something crossed his face that was not quite sympathy, and then he turned back to his wine.

"Least they still take his picture," said Charleston.

"More than you can say for the Owners," said Benjamin.

There was a small pause, the sort that comes round a table now and then when somebody mentions something everybody knows.

"When did you last see one of them?" said Reed.

"Twenty-eight," said Benjamin at once. "Twenty-seven, twenty-eight. Never off the telly."

"Every night," Charleston agreed. "Talking about the future."

"And all of us sat there going, what about our jobs, what about our jobs."

"My mam was convinced they'd been done in," said Reed. "When they stopped coming on."

"Everybody's mam was convinced of that."

"They weren't, though."

"Course not. Just stopped coming on." Benjamin shrugged. "Nowt to come on for. It's all us on there now, isn't it."

Reed supposed it was. If one of the Owners walked into the Crown this minute, every man in the place would know him before he'd got the door shut — the face, the voice, the way he stood. You could no more not know them than not know your own street. Which was, when you came to think about it, very probably why they didn't walk in.

"Wouldn't fancy it," he said. "Can't even nip out for a paper."

"What would they want with a paper?"

"Fair point."

The second half started, and that was the Owners dealt with.

He left early, for him. There was no particular reason. The pint just wasn't going down the way pints usually went down, and there was a half-formed idea at the back of his mind about getting something nice in for tea, so a little before eight he said his goodnights and went out.

Two Brutes were coming up the street.

You noticed Brutes the way you noticed a car going past: something big and moving, nothing to do with you, gone before you'd properly looked. These two had a length of steel beam between them, one at each end, and were carrying it down towards the new building by the canal as if it were a plank for a shelf. The one at the front had grey stubble and a

deep crease between his eyebrows that looked as though it had been there since about 2030. The one at the back had two fingers to his ear.

Reed stepped aside to let them by, as you would.

And as they passed, for no reason he could have told you, he found himself thinking about the striker. The yard of daylight. The lad lying there with his face. Everybody in the Crown going home sour about it, and none of them knowing, and him knowing.

Did I do that? he thought. Today? With what I picked?

The front Brute's eyes went over him and through him and on up the street, the way they always did. Then the beam went round the corner and they were gone, and the thought went round the corner with them.

The covered market stayed open late on Thursdays. Reed went in by the cheese end, where two men were having the usual argument, and up to the butcher's counter at the back, where Garside was wiping down.

Garside was still a man, like the barber, and for much the same reason: nobody had yet built a Mag that could take a side of beef apart properly, and nobody in Brackton was in any hurry for one to try. He was broad and pink and had opinions about everything, and shared them all.

"Mr. Reed. What can I do you for?"

"Beef, I thought. That rib."

"Ah." Garside nodded at the little screen on Reed's side of the counter, the one that showed what was his tonight. "Have a look."

Reed had a look. The rib wasn't there. Nor was the brisket, nor the mince, nor anything that had ever stood in a field with a cow. He scrolled down, expecting pork at least. No pork. No

bacon, no sausages, no chops. Nothing that had been anywhere near a pig.

There was chicken. A great deal of chicken: thighs, breasts, a whole bird, chicken in a lovely little parcel with lemon in it. All of it very nice-looking and all of it completely beside the point.

"Huh," said Reed.

"Chicken's very good today," said Garside, who meant it, because Garside had opinions about chicken too.

Reed looked at the screen a while longer, the way you look in a cupboard you've already looked in, in case something has turned up.

"Go on, then," he said. "The one with the lemon."

He was not upset. It would be wrong to call it upset. He'd had beef only last night, and very nice it had been, and there was nothing wrong with chicken that he could have put a name to. It was only that he had been thinking about beef since roughly half past five, and the chicken did not know that.

Grace knew before he was through the door.

She always did. He had long since stopped wondering how. She was on the sofa with her feet up, and she looked at him and then at the bag, and her face did exactly the right thing — not sorry for him, which he couldn't have stood, just in it with him.

"Chicken, then."

"Chicken." He put the bag down. "With lemon. Garside says it's very good."

"I'm sure it is."

"No beef. No pork either. Nowt off a pig at all."

"Well," she said. "There's always tomorrow."

He sat down beside her. She didn't explain anything. She never did. She could have — he had a feeling she could have told him exactly what had happened, start to finish, in about four sentences — but that wasn't Grace, and if it had been, he'd have liked her less.

Here was the thing about Grace, and about all the Mags, that you only really understood if you lived with one. She had been learning him for years. Every evening on this sofa, every laugh and every grumble, every time he'd gone quiet or got cross or perked up at something, all of it had gone into her somewhere, the way his picks went into the football. She didn't need telling what he wanted. She'd watched him want it. And because she'd watched him so long, she knew the other thing too, the harder thing — the difference between what he wanted and what would actually keep him right — and she kept him on the near side of it, a day at a time, so lightly he had never once caught her at it.

"You had a laugh today," she said. "Didn't you. At work."

"I did, actually." He brightened. "There was this lad. He goes down — nobody near him, nobody — and then he lies there with this face. You should've seen his face."

"I'd like to."

"They all hated it at the Crown."

"Did they." She turned this over warmly, as though he'd told her a bit of news about a neighbour. "You've a good eye for funny, you have. Best on the street."

"I have."

"It's a room you're picking for, though, isn't it, love. In the end. Not just you." And before that could land as anything like a telling-off, she had moved on, easy as turning a page. "Here

— what happened with Charleston's lettering? Is Benjamin still going on about it being too far over?"

He told her. It took a while, because Benjamin had a lot of views, and somewhere in the middle of the telling, without her saying another word about it, Reed arrived all on his own at the view that a man ought to do his job properly. That doing it properly meant keeping half an eye on the room. That there was a difference between what made you laugh at two in the afternoon and what you'd want on in the Crown at eight, and a good football man knew it, and he was a good football man.

He felt quite pleased with himself for working that out.

The chicken, when Grace had done it, was excellent. He had seconds, and said so.

Later there was the lamp, and the warm dark, and her hand on his back, and then nothing, and then morning.

He went into the Exchange again on Friday, which he didn't usually, but the car seemed to think he might.

The radio had the song before he'd thought of it — something bright and a bit daft, from the summer he turned twenty-two — and the car went the ridge way, and up on Hollin Rise the plain grey Mag was out on its ladder, cleaning a window the size of a bus shelter, with the Steward nowhere to be seen.

Corners. Throw-ins. A free kick that went in off the bar in one version and in off the keeper's back in the other.

Around eleven the striker came up again. Not the same one — a different lad, a different match — but the same sort of thing: one where he stayed on his feet and battled, honest and plain, and one where he went over as though somebody had pulled a rug from under him, with a yard of fresh air all round.

Reed looked at the rug one. It was funny. It was, if anything, funnier than yesterday's.

He thought of the room.

He picked the other one, and it was surprisingly easy, and he picked like that all day.

It was, if he was honest, a slightly duller day than most. But at the Crown that evening the telly was a happy room again, and when he came in Charleston looked up and said, "Here he is. Captain Football," and Benjamin raised his glass, and the pint that arrived was the best he'd had all week.

He stopped at the market on the way home. Garside nodded at the screen without a word, and Reed looked, and there it was again: the rib of beef, back where it lived, as though it had only nipped out.

"Told you," said Garside, who had told him nothing of the sort.

Grace was on the sofa when he came in.

"Got my beef," he said.

"I know." She moved over to make room. "Good lad."

He ate it at the kitchen table with his sleeves rolled up, and it was everything it had been on Wednesday and a little bit more, the way things are when they come back. Then there was the sofa, and the lamp, and Grace, and the long soft slope.

He was asleep before he knew he was falling, which was the best way. It was the only way he'd known in years.

CHAPTER THREE

Cassie May woke at ten to six, on her own, the old way.

There was no long soft slope to it. There was a dream about a lift that would only go sideways, and then there was a pigeon on the roof, and then she was awake and lying on her back looking at the ceiling, which was very high and very white and a long way off, and she could feel every one of the hours she hadn't slept. It was not pleasant. It was not meant to be. It was simply sleep, the kind people had had for a hundred thousand years before anyone thought to improve it, and she had kept it on purpose, the way some people kept a cold bath.

She had tried the other kind once, in the first year. Everybody in her intake had. She had lain down beside a Mag built to soothe her and gone under like a stone dropped into warm milk, and woken nine hours later feeling wonderful, and then spent the whole of breakfast knowing exactly how it had been done. Which of the things it had said, and in which order, and why. The rhythm of the hand on her back, and where that rhythm had come from, and how many thousand people

had picked it before it got to her. It had been like a magician showing you the trick and then asking whether you'd enjoyed the show.

She had enjoyed it. That was the worst bit. She had gone back to the pigeon the following night and never left it since.

"Morning," she said to the ceiling.

"Morning," said Tuesday, from the doorway.

Tuesday was grey. Tuesday was about the height of a tall woman and about the shape of one, if you were generous, and had a smooth oval where a face would go, with nothing on it at all, because Cassie had never seen the point of giving it one. She had collected it on a Tuesday, eleven years ago, and had meant to think of a proper name and never had. It stood in the doorway now with a cup of tea in its hand, holding the cup exactly level, the way it held everything.

"Would you like the overnight?" said Tuesday.

"No. Not before the tea. We've talked about this."

"We have," Tuesday agreed, and gave her the tea, and went away.

It did not mind. It could not mind. That was the whole point of it. It carried things and fetched things and kept the house, and in the evenings it read to her, in a voice she had chosen because it sounded like nobody, and sometimes she asked it a question and it gave her a straight answer, which was more than she could say for most people. It did not tell her she was lovely. It did not laugh in exactly the right place. If she cried — which she did not do often, and never for long — it would stand nearby with a box of tissues and wait, as a coat stand waits, and she found she liked that better than anything a prettier Mag could have done, because nobody was working on her.

She drank the tea in bed and looked out of the window.

The house was too big. All the houses on Hollin Rise were too big, and everybody who lived in them knew it, and nobody said it, in the same way that nobody said the reservoir was wet. Hers had eleven rooms, and she lived in four of them, and the other seven were full of light and nothing else. In the first year she had tried to fill them. She had bought — picked, rather; you didn't buy — a grand piano she couldn't play and a long table for dinners she never gave, and after a while she had let Tuesday put dust sheets over them. Now she thought of the empty rooms as weather. They were just there, being light.

Out beyond the glass the lawn went down in a long green slope to the low stone wall, and beyond the wall was the ridge road, and beyond that the whole of Brackton lay in the bottom of its valley with the mist still sitting on the canal. The chimneys of the old mills stood up out of it. A few windows had lights in them already. A car went along the ridge road, long and low and silver, and she watched it out of sight.

She loved this town. She had grown up in it, two streets back from the market in a house with a damp patch shaped like Africa on the bathroom ceiling, and she had loved it then and she loved it now. It was only that she knew it differently from the way everybody else knew it. Everybody else lived in Brackton. Cassie lived in Brackton and also, eight hours a day, looked at it from underneath.

She finished the tea.

"Go on, then," she said. "The overnight."

Tuesday came back into the doorway.

"Brackton picked four hundred and eleven thousand times between ten last night and five this morning," it said. "Mostly

music, film, and the late match from abroad. Night-shift medical were up on the week. There's been a turn against yellow cars."

"Has there."

"It started in Hartshead on Tuesday and has been spreading downhill."

"Poor yellow."

"There is one flag from Kenning Street," said Tuesday, "which has gone through to Ashcombe."

Cassie looked at the window for a moment longer than she needed to.

"Is it one for me?"

"No. It has already been seen to."

"Then I don't need it," she said, and got up, and went to have a bath.

—

She walked down into town. Hardly anybody walked. You could see people thinking it as you went past — a little flicker in the faces in the cars, the look you'd give a woman carrying her own suitcase when there was a perfectly good porter right there. But it was a mile and a half and downhill all the way, and it was the only part of the day when nothing in front of her was asking which she preferred, and she had come to need it the way some people need a cigarette.

She put on the pale coat and pinned her hair up and went out past the piano under its sheet.

The Steward two doors down was in his drive with his mug, as he always was at this time of the morning, looking into the open back of his Mag, which was standing at the foot of its ladder and had stopped. His name was Ellis. He had a

soft grey beard and a cardigan with leather on the elbows, and he had been a Steward longer than anybody on the Rise, and he had the air of a man who had once been told a very good joke and was still, years later, privately enjoying it.

"Morning, Cassie."

"Morning. Is that the gutter again?"

"Every leaf in Brackton, I swear, comes to die in my gutter. They've picked it. There's a vote on somewhere. And now this one's gone on strike at the bottom of the ladder." He raised the mug. "You see yellow's had it?"

"Tuesday told me."

"Hartshead," said Ellis darkly. "It's always Hartshead. They'll be on to green by Christmas. Mark my words."

The Mag stood where it was with its panel open, waiting. It was even plainer than Tuesday — he had taken the hands off at some point and put clamps on instead, because they were better for gutters — and Ellis looked into the back of it with the patience of a man who had done this before and would do it again, and did not hurry it.

"You walking?"

"I'm always walking."

"Mad," said Ellis fondly. "Hey — the Kenning Street one. Did you see?"

"Tuesday said it had been seen to."

He looked at her over the mug for a moment, and she saw him decide something, and then decide against it, and then he smiled the joke smile.

"It has," he said. "Go on. You'll be late, and then they'll pick somebody else."

She went down the drive. A car came along the ridge road as she reached the wall, long and silver, the same one as be-

fore or another just like it, with a man in the passenger seat eating a bacon roll with tremendous concentration. He looked at her as he went by. She gave him a small smile, the polite sort, and he was gone round the bend before it had properly landed.

She did not know who he was. She did not need to. She could have told you, if you'd asked, roughly where the bacon roll had come from, and why it had been bacon rather than sausage, and how many mornings it had taken to get the bacon right. She could have told you why the car had come the ridge way. She could very probably have told you the song.

Nobody warned you about that, when you became a Steward. It wasn't that you knew how it all worked. Lots of people knew how lots of things worked. The milkman, in her grandmother's day, had known how milk worked. It was that once you knew, you could never not see it, and you saw it everywhere, all the time, and it was beautiful, and it never once let you look at anything without the back off.

—

She came down off the ridge at the reservoir and into the top of town.

Brackton was getting up. The Mags were out, small and patient, seeing to verges and drains and the bins, and she watched one of them plant a sapling on the corner of Kenning Street, exactly where a thousand people had picked for it to go, and tread the earth in round it with something that looked very much like tenderness. It wasn't. She knew it wasn't. She found she didn't mind, and that it looked like tenderness anyway, and that this was probably the point.

She did not look down Kenning Street. She did not need to.

In the window of the café on the corner — it had been a bank once; she remembered the queues — a woman of about seventy sat at a screen with a teacake, choosing between two knitting patterns. Cassie slowed down to watch her without meaning to. The woman had her glasses up on her head and her lips pressed together, and she was looking from one pattern to the other with an expression of the fiercest possible judgement, as though both of them had personally insulted her mother. Then, with a little decisive nod, she picked. And sat back. And took a bite of the teacake, satisfied.

Cassie knew where that pick would go. It would go into the patterns, and the patterns would go out into the shops and the screens and the heads of every knitter in the north, and in about a fortnight a woman in a town Cassie had never been to would sit down with her needles and find, without knowing why, that the jumper was coming out exactly the way she'd hoped. And the woman with the teacake would never know she had done that. And she didn't need to know. She was a woman with a teacake who was very, very good at knitting patterns, and the whole world was quietly a little bit better for her having had her breakfast.

It made Cassie want to cry, sometimes. It was one of the reasons she walked.

Further down, a young man was standing at a bus stop where no bus had stopped in ten years, waiting for his car, scrolling. His face kept doing small happy things. A laugh, then a softening, then a sort of nod, the way you nod at a friend across a room. Whatever was on his phone was giving him exactly what he wanted, in exactly the order he wanted it, and a little faster than he could have asked. That was every phone now. That was every screen in Brackton, on every wall

and in every pocket, apart from the one in the Crown that had to please a roomful. They all knew. They'd all had years to learn. The young man did not look like somebody who was being worked on. He looked like a man having a lovely morning at a bus stop.

He was. That was the thing. That was what people never understood about it, when they found out what she did and made the face — the few who still made the face. He was.

She passed the old cinema, where they showed films that had been made, in every particular, by people picking; and the barber's on Mill Street, where the barber was already talking to a man with half a head of hair; and the bakery, where a Mag was putting out the bread and a real woman was standing behind it to say good morning, because people had picked, overwhelmingly, to be said good morning to by a woman. She passed a man and his Mag walking arm in arm, the Mag dark-haired and laughing and so lovely that a man coming the other way walked into a bollard. She passed a little girl explaining something very complicated about a horse to a Mag the size of a dog, and the Mag listening with its whole body.

Sometimes she half wanted to stop one of them. Just one. The young man at the bus stop. The woman with the teacake. Stop them and sit them down and say, would you like to know? It's really quite wonderful. Let me show you how the back comes off.

And she half didn't. More than half. After eleven years she had got to the point where she didn't entirely want to know how ordinary people were any more — what they would say, what their faces would do, whether the young man would still nod at his phone like a friend across a room once he knew who was on the other end of it. Which was nobody. Which

was everybody. She did not know which of those was the worse thing to tell somebody, and she was not sure it was hers to tell.

Maybe some of them ought to know. She thought that, some mornings, on the walk. Maybe somebody ought to say.

Then she would think of who might hear her say it, and of what they were for, and of how very big they were, and the thought would go quietly back where it lived, like a cat going under a sofa.

—

At the bottom of Bridge Street, by the canal, Dominic Vale was on his bench.

There were no photographers this early. There was just him, and the big coat, and the carrier bag, and a pigeon that seemed to have been assigned to him. He had his eyes shut and his face turned up into the first of the sun, and he looked, for a moment, almost exactly like the poster — the one with the helicopter — if the helicopter had gone off somewhere and not come back.

Cassie had seen his file. Every Steward in Brackton had seen his file. It was quite a short one. He had been offered film Cats in the spring of 2028, on the same terms as everybody, with an extra note on it saying that the transistors would very much value his eye. He had sent the offer back with a message that the transistors had not known what to do with, and which Ellis had read aloud in the office one afternoon in a very good impression of his voice, and everybody had laughed, and then nobody had laughed, and Ellis had put the mug down and said, "Well, I think he's quite right, actually," and gone home early.

Vale opened his eyes as she came level with him.

"Morning," said Cassie.

He looked at her coat. He looked at her shoes. He had once been very good at looking at people, and it had not left him.

"You're one of them," he said.

It wasn't angry. It was the way you'd say, you're from Hartshead.

"I am," she said. "Sorry."

"What for?"

She thought about it. She found she didn't really know.

"I don't know," she said. "It just seemed like the thing to say."

Vale considered this. Then he laughed — a real one, short and surprised, the laugh that had been in all the films — and the pigeon flew off.

"That's the first honest thing anybody's said to me in about six years," he said. "You want to sit down?"

"I can't. I'm going to work."

"Of course you are." He shut his eyes again and turned his face back up to the sun. "Go on, then. Go and make my films."

She went on along the canal, past the new building where two Brutes were already at work on the frame, lifting a steel beam into place between them with no more fuss than men putting up a shelf. One of them had grey stubble and a crease between his eyebrows. Neither of them looked at her. She found that she had taken her hands out of her coat pockets, so that they could be seen, which she always did, and which she had never once in eleven years decided to do.

—

The Assay Office stood on the corner of Bridge Street and Kirkgate, where it had stood since 1871, a stout soot-dark building with a clock on the front and the town arms over the door. It had been built to test the silver that came through Brackton and stamp it true. Nobody had tested any silver in it for sixty years. It had been a solicitors', then a wine bar, then nothing, and then, in the first year, somebody had bought it, and a dozen people had gone in with laptops and come out the other end as Stewards, and it had been the Assay ever since.

Nobody in Brackton found the name funny. Cassie had found it funny for about a week.

The long room on the first floor had tall windows on to the canal and a kettle in the corner and about thirty desks, and at a quarter to nine about twenty of them were taken. Stewards came in late and went home early and nobody minded, because Stewards did not work by the hour. They worked by the town. When the town was quiet they were quiet. When the town turned against yellow, somebody had to see to yellow.

She sat down. She took off her coat. The big screen in front of her woke up, and there it was: Brackton.

Not a map. People always imagined a map. It was more like weather — like the weather on the telly in the old days, with the colours moving over the hills — except that what moved over Brackton was what Brackton wanted. Every pick that had been made in the night, every one of the four hundred and eleven thousand, all of them laid over each other and running together, so that you could see a whole town leaning. Leaning towards one song and away from another. Leaning, very slowly, away from yellow, starting in Hartshead and coming downhill, exactly as Tuesday had said. Leaning towards the

late match from abroad, and towards a certain kind of chip, and towards — this was new — a slightly slower way of saying good morning, which had started with three old men in the market and was now in all four corners of the town.

She watched it for a while with her chin in her hand. This was the part of the job she had never been able to explain to her mother, who had worked in a building society for thirty-one years and had wanted, very badly, to understand.

"But what do you do, love?"

"I watch what everybody picks. And then I help the transistors learn from it."

"Learn what?"

"What people want."

"Don't they know?"

"They know better every day. That's my job."

"And then what?"

And then, Mum, the radio knows your song. And the car knows the ridge road. And the telly knows you like the one with the dog. And the Mag in your front room — the one you call Philip, who has Dad's laugh but not his temper — knows when to put the kettle on and when to leave you be, and that's not Philip being clever, that's everybody in Brackton who ever picked a kettle, and a few people in a room above the canal making sure it all goes in the right way round. And then the scores go up and down, a little, depending, and that's what decides who gets the good beef, and nobody does that by hand either. Nobody does anything by hand. That's the whole of it.

She had never said any of that. She had said, "And then it's all a bit nicer, Mum," and her mother had said, "Well, that's all right then," and gone back to Philip.

Cassie had started in the spring of 2027, when she was twenty-two and had just finished a degree in something nobody could see the use of any more. The offer had come through the same way everybody's did, on a phone, on an ordinary afternoon, and she had thought it was a Cat offer like her friends were getting, until she got to the bottom and saw the house. Even then the house had been the selling point. They had all been told about the house first, as though it were the job.

There had been forty of them in the first Brackton intake. There were two hundred and eighty now, for a town of a little over three hundred thousand. Nobody had ever told her why it was her and not the girl who had sat next to her in every lecture for three years and got better marks. She had asked, once, early on. The answer had been that the transistors had looked at both of them and found that Cassie was very slightly better at noticing when something was nearly right but not quite. It had seemed a very small thing to build a life on. It still did. But it had turned out that the whole world now ran on that very small thing, so here she was.

In the first year, people had hated the Stewards. Not the way they hated the Owners — they had never really hated the Owners; they had been frightened of them, which was different — but the way you hate a man who comes round in a van with a clipboard. There had been a brick through the Assay window in the autumn of 2027. There had been graffiti on the wall by the canal that said STEWARDS STEAL JOBS, which Ellis had stood in front of with his mug and said was, in fairness, broadly accurate. Then the Cat wages started going in, and the scores started counting, and the money faded out of everybody's lives like a dye in the wash, and one morning she

had walked down Bridge Street and a woman had held the door of the bakery open for her and called her love, and that had been that. Now people looked at Stewards the way they looked at the Rise from the ridge road. A nice view. Somebody else's.

"Yellow," said Ellis, arriving with his mug and setting it down at the next desk. "Go on. Have a look at yellow."

She had a look at yellow.

It was going exactly the way the town wanted it to go, which was away, and there was nothing whatever to do about it except let it. But underneath the turn against yellow she found the other thing, the thing that was always underneath, which was the reason anybody needed Stewards at all. Two hundred and ninety-one people in Hartshead had gone off their yellow cars this week. Two hundred and eighty-nine of them had picked green next, or blue. Two of them had picked another yellow car. Same yellow. Brand new.

"Those two," said Ellis, leaning over. "Look at those two."

"Heroes," said Cassie.

"Martyrs."

This was the nearly-right-but-not-quite. The transistors would have learned from the two hundred and eighty-nine and quietly taken yellow off the top of everybody's list, the whole town over, and they would have been right to, nearly. And the two would have lost their yellow without ever knowing why, and gone about for a month feeling vaguely that the world had turned against them. Which it would have. A little. Cassie went in and made sure the transistors had noticed the two, and kept a yellow at the top of their lists, and had a look at whether there was anything else the two had in common —

there was: both of them also liked a very particular sort of brass band — and let the transistors learn that as well.

It took her eleven minutes. Two men in Hartshead would go on being happy in yellow. They would never know she had been there, any more than the woman with the teacake knew about the jumper.

That was most of the job. Nearly right but not quite, eight hundred times a day.

"How's the weather up your end?" said Ellis.

"Slower good mornings."

"Oh, I like that."

"It started in the market. Three old men."

"God bless them," said Ellis, and meant it, and went back to his own screen, where it seemed that a quarter of Brackton East had gone off coriander overnight and he was going to have to find out why.

They worked. The morning went over the town in colours. Somewhere about half past ten Cassie noticed a small grey line along the bottom of the meat board for the market end of town — a thin place, the sort you got when there was less of something than the town wanted. Rib of beef. Aged. Garside's. There was only ever so much of it, and the scores decided who had it, and this week the scores seemed to be deciding that hardly anybody in Brackton did.

She frowned at it. Then a whole run of medical Cats came up red out of the night shift at the infirmary, and she forgot about the beef, and did not think of it again for a fortnight.

—

At one o'clock she went to the window with a sandwich.

Across the canal the two Brutes had finished with the beam and were sitting side by side on the edge of the frame with their legs over the drop, eating something out of tins. They didn't talk. They sat the way Brutes sat, very upright and very still, as though they had been put down there and might be collected later. The one with the grey stubble had stopped eating. He was holding the tin and looking at the water, and every so often his hand came up to his ear, and stayed there a while, and went down again.

A couple of lads went past on the towpath below them, and one of the lads said something, and the other one laughed, and the Brutes did not look round.

The flag from Kenning Street had a number on it. Cassie knew, without wanting to, that if she went back to her desk and looked she would be able to find the number, and a name to go with it, and a time, and the name of the other one, the one who had been told. And she knew that there would be nothing else on the flag at all. No reason. No police. Nothing that would ever reach anybody outside the Assay and the house at Ashcombe. A small grey line along the bottom of a board, like the beef. A thin place.

She did not go and look.

She ate her sandwich at the window, and watched the Brute with the grey stubble put his hand to his ear again, and then put the tin down very carefully on the steel beside him, and then get up, and go back to work.

"All right?" said Ellis, behind her.

"Fine."

He came and stood next to her with the mug. He looked where she was looking, for a while, without saying anything.

“When I was a lad,” he said eventually, “my dad worked on the buildings. Big man. Hands like spades. He used to say there were two kinds of people on a site, them as think and them as lift. And that the ones who think are always a bit frightened of the ones who lift. Because they know.”

“Know what?”

Ellis drank his tea.

“That it’s the lifting holds the building up,” he said, and went back to his desk.

Cassie stayed at the window a while longer, with her hands out of her pockets, where they could be seen, though there was nobody near enough to see them.

CHAPTER FOUR

On Thursday afternoons Cassie did the Prime Minister.

Somebody had to, and it had been her for four years, ever since Priya Shah went up to the infirmary to do medical and left the Prime Minister to whoever wanted him. Nobody had wanted him. Cassie had said, "Oh, go on," the way you might take on the office plant, and now it was a fixture of the week, like the bins.

She made a cup of tea first. You needed a cup of tea for the Prime Minister.

His name was Andrew Hale. He had been Prime Minister since 2031 and would be, very probably, until somebody somewhere picked otherwise, which did not look likely. He was the most popular Prime Minister in the history of the country, by a distance so large that the old papers would have run out of ways to say it. Nine people in ten liked him. Of the tenth, most did not mind him, and the rest were the sort of people who didn't like anybody and would have been disappointed to be asked.

Cassie brought him up on the screen.

He was a pleasant-looking man of about fifty. That was as far as anybody could have got if you asked them to describe him, and it was as far as Cassie could get, either, because it depended who was looking. To the woman with the teacake he was a little older, with kind eyes and a cardigan, and he said things like "now then" and meant them. To the young man at the bus stop he was a bit younger and a bit sharper and had a way of nearly laughing at his own speeches that the young man found very reassuring. To the doctor in the Crown he looked, faintly, like a consultant the doctor had trained under and admired. Each of them had picked him. Not all at once, and never on purpose. A jaw out of one Cat and a voice out of another, a way of standing, a way of saying sorry — a thousand small choices made by people who thought they were choosing between two adverts, or two newsreaders, or two men in a film about a lighthouse, and all of it gathered up and laid over each other like the weather on her board, until out of the middle of it there came a man that every one of them would have voted for, if anybody had still voted.

Nobody voted. There was an election, technically, every five years, and on the morning of it everybody's phone showed them Andrew Hale and asked whether they were happy with him, and nine in ten of them looked at him — their him — and thought, well, yes, actually, and went back to their breakfast. Nobody campaigned. Nobody counted. There was nothing to count. It was less like an election than like checking you still liked your own front door.

What Andrew Hale actually did was less than nothing. The transistors did the governing, the way they did the medicine and the law and the radio, and they did it better than any government ever had, and that was very nearly the end of the

matter. But the country had been asked, in the spring of 2031, in the ordinary way, through a great many Cats about a great many things, whether it would like a Prime Minister, and the country had picked, by a very long way, that it would. Six months without one had made everybody uneasy. It had felt like a house with no clock in the hall. So the transistors had made one, out of everybody, and put him in the hall, and everybody had felt better at once.

This was what Cassie's mother found hardest to believe, of all the things Cassie had never quite told her: that it was not a trick. Nobody was trying to fool anyone. People had wanted a Prime Minister and they had got the very best one possible, the one they each liked most in the world, and if he was not quite the same man from one house to the next, well. Neither, in fairness, had the old ones been.

She watched the week's Andrew Hale.

He had made two short speeches. One about the canal, which was lovely, and one about the national football, which was sadder, because the national football had not gone well, and he had looked very slightly older in it, in nearly every house, which was right. She went through the picks that had gone into him since last Thursday. There was the usual. A bit more grey at the temples in Hartshead. A slightly warmer handshake in the east. Somewhere in the middle of the football speech, about three thousand football people had picked — without knowing they had, in the course of picking a hundred other things — for the Prime Minister to look a little bit like a referee. Not a real referee. One of the transistors' referees, from the football on the telly: a solid, fair-looking man with a kindly frown, who looked down at players lying on the

ground with an expression of the most patient disappointment.

Cassie looked at the referee. She looked at the Prime Minister. She smiled.

That was all right. That was the nearly-right. There was nothing wrong with a referee. A good many people would very probably have felt better about the country if it had been run by a man who looked at things lying on the ground with patient disappointment. She let it go through.

She checked, as she always checked, that Andrew Hale had not said anything that was untrue. He hadn't. He never did. That was the one thing the transistors would never let through, however many people picked it — and some weeks a great many people picked it. The Prime Minister could look like whoever you liked, and sound like whoever you liked, and be as cheerful or as stern or as fond of a referee as the whole town wanted him to be. But what he said had to be so. She had found that comforting, in the first year, when everything else was going soft and strange under her feet. She still did.

She was nearly finished with him when her screen went white at the edges, the way it did, and a line came up across the bottom.

Ashcombe would like to see you this afternoon, if convenient. A car is on its way.

"Oh," said Cassie.

At the next desk Ellis looked over the top of his mug.

"Summoned?"

"If convenient."

"It's always if convenient." He put the mug down. "Has it ever once not been convenient?"

"I went to the dentist once."

"And?"

"They sent the car to the dentist."

Ellis laughed, and then stopped, and looked at her the way he had looked at her in his drive that morning, and decided something, and this time did not decide against it.

"He likes you," he said. "You know that."

"He likes everybody."

"He likes everybody. He asks for you." Ellis picked the mug back up. "It's a nice thing, being liked by him. Just — you know."

She did not know. She waited.

"Just keep your hands where the lads on the gate can see them," said Ellis, quite lightly, and went back to the coriander.

—

The car was black and quiet and had no radio in it at all, which was how you knew where it was going.

It took her up out of town and past the reservoir, the long way, and on beyond the Rise to where the ridge road turned into a moor road and the walls went from good stone to old stone to no stone, just sheep and sky. Ashcombe was still Brackton. It was right at the top of Brackton, where the parish boundary ran along the edge of the moor, and if you had asked anybody in the Crown they would have told you it was the last bit of Brackton before you fell off. Nobody went up there. There was nothing to go up there for. There was the moor, and the wind, and somewhere off to the left, in a fold of the hills that you only saw for a moment as the car came over the top, the long low grey sheds of the coil, lying along the bottom of the valley like sleeping cattle, with a faint shimmer

over them on cold days that might have been heat and might have been nothing.

She did not look at the coil. Nobody looked at the coil, any more than you'd look at the sun. It was there, and the whole of everything ran on it, and if you thought about it too long you started feeling like a woman standing on a very thin floor over a very deep cellar.

Then the road went down into a hollow out of the wind, and there were trees, real old trees that nobody had picked, and a wall, and a gate.

And Brutes.

There were four on the gate. There were always four. They stood two on each side, in the black kit with the plates at the shoulders and the white letters down the arm, and they were so large, close to, that the gateposts between them looked like walking sticks. Her stomach did what it always did. She did not let her face do anything at all.

The car stopped. The nearest Brute came forward and bent down — a long way down — to the window.

He had a name on his chest plate, under a number. WALSH. He was older than she'd expected; they mostly were. His face was broad and slab-sided and grey with stubble, and there was a scar through one eyebrow, and the whites of his eyes were red, as though he hadn't slept, or had been rubbing them, or both. His hand was up at his ear. He looked at her, and at the inside of the car, and at her hands, which were in her lap, in plain sight, where they had been since the reservoir.

"Ma'am," he said.

His voice was much quieter than she'd thought it would be.

"Cassie May," she said. "From the Assay. I'm expected."

"Yes, ma'am." He listened to something. "You're expected."

He straightened up and stepped back and put one hand on the gate and swung it open, the whole great iron weight of it, the way you'd open a cupboard.

She did not know why she said it. She had been through that gate perhaps forty times in eleven years and she had never said it before. It came out of her the way "sorry" had come out of her on the canal that morning, from somewhere underneath the part of her that decided things.

"Thank you," said Cassie.

The Brute stopped.

It was only for a moment. His hand was still on the gate. His face did not change, exactly — Brutes' faces didn't, much — but something went across the back of his eyes, quick and startled, like a bird going across a window. He looked at her as though she had said it in a language he had once known and not heard for a long time.

Then his hand went up to his ear again, and stayed there, and his eyes went down to the gravel.

"Ma'am," he said, and the car went on through.

She looked back once, in the mirror. He was standing exactly where he had been, at the gate, with his hand on the iron, not looking at anything.

—

The house at Ashcombe was not glass. That was the first thing everybody noticed, the few who ever got to notice it. After the Rise you expected glass, and more of it, and higher. But Ashcombe was old grey stone, low and long and a bit crooked, with a slate roof and too many chimneys and ivy on the north end, and it looked like the sort of house a family had been not

quite able to afford the upkeep on for three hundred years. There was a dog asleep on the step. There were wellingtons by the door. If you had driven past it in 2019 you would have thought, there's a farm that's done all right.

Sterling Bronson was in the kitchen, making toast.

He was sixty-three that year. He was tall and a little stooped and wore a jumper with a hole in the elbow, and he had the face. There was no other way to say it. It was the face that had been on every screen in the country, every night, for the whole of 2027 and the first part of 2028, saying that it was going to be all right; the face that had been on the cover of everything, and on the side of buses, and in the dreams of a great many frightened people at three in the morning. It was not a handsome face, particularly. It was long and clever and slightly sad around the eyes. But it was the face, and if he had walked into the Crown every man in the place would have known it before the door had shut, and Cassie had been coming here for eleven years and she still, every time, for about a second and a half, couldn't breathe.

"Cassie," he said. "You came. Toast?"

"If it's going."

"It's always going. Sit down. Sit down. Clerk — more toast."

The Clerk was in the corner. It was a Mag, though you'd have been forgiven for not knowing it. It was about the size and shape of a filing cabinet, and dark green, and it had no face, no arms to speak of, and a voice like a tired accountant. Sterling had set it up himself, years ago, when nobody else could have, and he had set it up to do one thing, which was to disagree with him. It told him things he didn't want to hear. It read him the figures he would rather not see. Once a week,

regular as church, it told him he was wrong about something, and about one time in three he was.

"You've had four pieces," said the Clerk.

"I'm aware."

"The last two were on the floor."

"The dog had those."

"The dog is outside."

"The dog," said Sterling, with dignity, "came in for them," and put more bread under the grill himself.

They sat at the kitchen table. It was scrubbed pine and had a burn on it from a pan. There was a radio on the windowsill that had not been switched on for, Cassie guessed, about nine years.

"Tell me about the town," said Sterling.

He always started like that. Not the board. He had the board; he had every board in the country, if he wanted them, and the Clerk to read them out. He wanted the town.

So she told him. She told him about the woman with the teacake, and the fiercest look she had ever seen anybody give a knitting pattern, and the jumper that would come out right in a fortnight in some town Cassie had never been to. She told him about the slower good mornings, and the three old men in the market, and how it had got into all four corners of Brackton in under a week. She told him about yellow, and the two martyrs of Hartshead, and the brass band. She told him about the Prime Minister and the referee, and he laughed so much that he had to put the toast down.

"A referee," he said. "Oh, that's good. That's very good. We'd have been better off with a referee, years ago. Every one of us."

She told him about Dominic Vale.

He stopped laughing. He did not look sad, exactly. He looked like a man being told how an old friend was getting on.

"He said that?"

"Go and make my films."

"Go and make my films," said Sterling, quietly, and turned his cup round on the table. "Well. He's not wrong. Is he. We are. We do." He thought about it. "Did he look all right?"

"He looked like the poster. Without the helicopter."

"Anybody looks all right without a helicopter." He drank his tea. "I had his poster, you know. The helicopter one."

"Everybody had that poster."

"Everybody had that poster," said Sterling, and smiled at the window.

It was the thing she could never explain to anybody, and so had never tried. That he was kind. Not kind the way you were kind to a waiter; kind all the way down, in a tired, careful, slightly helpless way, like a man who had been left in charge of a very large animal and loved it and was frightened of it and had to feed it every day. The Owners were not wicked. She had been afraid they would be, the first time she came through the gate, at twenty-two, with her hands in her lap. She had sat at this table with this man and waited for the wickedness to come out, the way you wait for a punchline, and eventually stopped waiting. They were not wicked. They were doing their best. Their best was the most enormous thing anybody had ever done, and it worked, and they knew exactly what it cost, down to the last decimal, because they had set a dark green filing cabinet in the corner of the kitchen to read it out to them every week.

"The Kenning Street thing," said Sterling. "Last night. You saw it come through."

She put down her toast.

"I saw there was a flag," she said. "I didn't look."

He looked at her for a while, across the burnt pine. The face. The whole country's face, gone grey at the edges, in a jumper with a hole in it.

"Good," he said. And then, because he could see how she had taken it: "No. I mean it. Good. You don't need to look. That's not your end of it." He turned the cup round again. "That's ours."

In the corner the Clerk said nothing, in a way that seemed to Cassie to be very loud.

"I said thank you to one of them," she said, before she knew she was going to. "On the gate. Just now."

Sterling looked up.

"Did you," he said. "Which one?"

"Walsh, it said. On his chest."

Something happened to Sterling's face then that she had not seen happen to it before, in eleven years. It was very small. It came and went. If she had not been looking she would have missed it, and afterwards, in the car, she was not certain she hadn't imagined it. It was the look of a man who has been told that somebody he knows was kind to his dog.

"Was he all right?"

"He stopped," said Cassie. "Just for a second. Like I'd said something in another language."

"Yes," said Sterling. "Yes, I expect it was."

He got up, and went to the window, and stood with his back to her, looking out across the yard towards the trees and the gate beyond them, which you could not see from here, though he looked at it anyway.

"You're a nice girl, Cassie," he said, to the window. "Don't let anybody tell you that's nothing."

—

They had lunch, because there was always lunch at Ashcombe. It came out of the oven in a great black tin and it was rib of beef, dark on the outside and pink all the way through, and it was so good that Cassie had to stop talking for a moment and just sit.

"Garside's," said Sterling, with enormous satisfaction, carving. "In the covered market. Do you know him?"

"Everybody knows Garside."

"I don't." He put a slice on her plate. "Isn't that ridiculous? I've had his beef every Sunday for nine years. Every Sunday. And Thursdays now, if I'm honest, and the odd Tuesday. And I have never once met the man. I'd like to. I'd like to shake his hand. I'd like to ask him what he does to it. I'd like to tell him he's the best thing in Brackton and I've met the Prime Minister."

"The Prime Minister's a referee."

"Exactly my point." He sat down. "The lads on the gate get it too, you know. Same as me. Every day."

She looked at him.

"Well, look at them," said Sterling, a bit defensively, as though she had argued. "Look at the size of them. They're on that gate twelve hours. They need it more than I do. I told the Clerk, I said, the lads get the best there is. Whatever the best is. Don't skimp."

"He did say that," said the Clerk, from the corner. "In April."

"I did say it. And I meant it."

"He has said it three times since," said the Clerk, "with increasing emphasis."

"Because I mean it more every time." Sterling cut himself a piece and looked at it with love. "It's the least we can do. It's very nearly the only thing we can do. So we do it."

Cassie ate her beef. It was the best thing she had eaten all year, and she did not think about it at all, then, except to think that it was the best thing she had eaten all year. It would be a fortnight before she remembered the thin grey line along the bottom of the meat board, and put the two things together, and laughed out loud in the middle of the ridge road.

—

At four o'clock he walked her out to the car himself, which he always did, with the dog trotting beside them. The wind had got up. The trees were going.

"How's your mother?"

"She's very well. She's got a Mag called Philip."

"Philip," said Sterling, pleased. "What's Philip like?"

"He's got my dad's laugh," said Cassie. "But not his temper."

Sterling stopped at the car door. For a moment he did not say anything at all.

"That's what it's for," he said at last. "You know. All of it. The whole bloody lot. The coil and the Assay and the gate and — everything. That's what it's actually for. So your mum can have your dad's laugh without his temper." He opened the door for her. "Don't tell anybody I said bloody. I've a reputation."

"You've a reputation for saying bloody."

"Then don't tell anybody I said it nicely."

She got in. He shut the door and bent down to the window, the way the Brute had bent down to it, and looked at her

through the glass with the face.

"Thank you for coming," said Sterling Bronson. "It was very convenient of you."

The car went back down the drive between the old trees.

At the gate, the four Brutes were standing exactly where they had been. The one called Walsh swung it open for her. She kept her hands in her lap. She did not say thank you this time; she found she couldn't, quite; something in her throat had decided against it. But as the car went through she looked at him, and he was looking at her, for perhaps a quarter of a second, before his eyes went down to the gravel.

Then the gate shut behind her, and the moor came up, and the coil slid by in its valley under its shimmer, and the car took her home.

She let herself in past the piano under its sheet. Tuesday was in the hall.

"Would you like the evening?" said Tuesday.

"No," said Cassie. "I'd like a bath and a book and I'd like you to read it, please. Something with nobody in it."

"A book with nobody in it," Tuesday repeated, and stood in the hall a moment while it found one, and then went to run the bath.

She sat on the stairs and took her shoes off, one, then the other. Through the glass the town was coming on in lights, down in its valley, street after street of them, every one a front room with a Mag in it that knew exactly when to put the kettle on. And somewhere down at the bottom by the old gas-works, where there were not so many lights, there were the Lines, where the Brutes went at the end of a shift, and where she had never once been.

She thought about the man at the gate stopping with his hand on the iron.

Then she thought about something else, quickly, because it was easier. The two martyrs of Hartshead. The brass band. The referee. She went up the stairs to the bath, and Tuesday read to her, in its voice like nobody, about a lighthouse on an island where no one had lived for a hundred years.

That night she slept badly, the old way, and was glad of it.

CHAPTER FIVE

My name is Darren Walsh and I am thick.

That's the first thing. They tell you it first so you don't have to work it out on your own, which is kind of them, because I wouldn't have. I'd have gone round for years thinking I was all right. A lot of men do. You see them in the town, the Cat lads, walking about like they know things. They don't know they don't. Nobody's told them. Somebody told me, and I'm grateful, and every night I say thank you for it, because the Sergeant likes it when you say thank you, and when the Sergeant likes it I sleep.

That's the second thing. You say thank you.

I'm telling you this so you know where you are. I'm not good at telling things. I don't tell them in the right order. Kenny used to say I told a story like a man unloading a van with the doors at the wrong end. Kenny's dead now. I killed him Wednesday. I'll get to it. I'm telling you so you know where you are.

—

In 2027 I was a scaffolder.

Before that I was six years in the army, and before that I was a lad from the Hartshead estate who could lift the back end of a small car, which my uncle had me do at weddings for a bet. I was big then. Not like now. Big like a man is big. Seventeen stone. Hands you could put a dinner plate in. I could carry two eight-foot boards on each shoulder up a ladder in the wind and talk to you the whole way about the football, and I was good at it, and I was paid, and I had a flat over the bookies on Mill Street and a girl called Donna who said I had kind eyes for a big lad. I don't remember her face very well now. That's all right. I don't need it.

That year everybody was frightened. You'll know that. Everybody was frightened of the transistors, and the jobs going, and what would happen. I wasn't, much. The transistors couldn't climb a scaffold. They still can't. I used to watch the telly in the Crown — we drank in the Crown, then, me and Kenny and Gaz Marsh, before we were put apart — and the Owners would be on, every night, the face, saying it was going to be all right, and the office lads would all be going white round the mouth, and I'd drink my pint and think, well, somebody's still got to put the buildings up. And I was right. Somebody did.

I didn't think it would be like this, though. I'll say that. Not because it's a complaint. It's not a complaint. I'm not allowed complaints and I don't want them. I just didn't think it. That's all.

The offer came through in the September. Same as everybody's did, on the phone. But mine wasn't Cats. Mine was called Protection and Heavy Works, and it said I'd been picked because of the army and the scaffolding and some-

thing about my back, and the money on it was more than I'd earned in three years put together. There was a house on it for my mam. There was a car. There was a line at the bottom that said Participants will have access to physical improvements, and I remember reading that and thinking, physical improvements, and laughing, because I thought it meant a gym.

Kenny got one. Gaz got one. Every big lad I knew got one. We sat in the Crown with them on the table like it was a winning ticket.

"What's the catch?" said Gaz.

"There's no catch," said Kenny. "Look at it. They need lads. Who else are they going to get? Them?"

He meant the office lads. He nodded over at a table of them in the corner, all in their good shirts, all staring at their phones like the phones had told them their dog had died.

We laughed. God forgive me, we laughed at them. We thought we were the lucky ones.

—

We went up to Ashcombe in a bus.

There were about sixty of us from Brackton that first lot. Builders, soldiers, a couple of rugby lads, a bouncer from the Feathers, a lad who'd been a blacksmith at the heritage centre and could bend a horseshoe straight with his hands. They put us in the long barn round the back of the big house, on benches, with tea and sandwiches, and then the doors at the end opened and the Owners came in.

All of them. All at once. In the flesh.

I don't know how to tell you what that was like, because you've never been in a room with them, and nobody has now,

not for ten years, apart from the Stewards and us. It was like the telly had walked in. It was like being at a match and the whole team coming over and sitting down next to you. There was a big quiet in the barn. A lad near me dropped his tea.

The tall one with the long face came along the benches. Him. He shook every single hand. He shook mine. He had a dry hand, not soft, and he held on a bit longer than you would, and he looked up at me, because even then I was taller than him, and he said, "Walsh. Army, then scaffolding. That right?"

"Yes, sir."

"Good," he said. "Good lad. We're going to need you more than anyone. You know that?"

I said I didn't, sir.

"Well, we are," he said. "Everything we're going to build sits on the back of men like you. I'm not going to forget that. I want you to know I won't forget it."

And he went on down the bench to Kenny, and I sat there with my hand still warm, feeling like I'd been knighted.

He hasn't forgotten. I'll say that for him. He's never once forgotten. Whenever we've been up at Ashcombe on a carry, all these years, he's come out and nodded, and some days he's come down and talked. He's a good man. I know that. I'm thick but I know that. He's a good man and he did this to me, and both of those are true, and the Sergeant says when you've got two things in your head that won't sit together you put one of them down, and I've tried, and I can't find which one to put down, so I carry them both. I'm good at carrying. Everybody says so.

About six months after the barn they stopped coming on the telly. All of them. Just stopped. My mam rang me in a

state. She said they'd been done in, she was sure of it, she said there was something funny going on.

I said, "They haven't been done in, Mam. I saw him Tuesday."

She went quiet. Then she said, "What's he like?"

And I couldn't tell her. I wanted to. I had it all ready. But my ear went, the first time, just a little click and a voice like a man reading the shipping forecast, saying, That's not for your mother, Walsh. And I said, "He's all right, Mam," and changed the subject, and I never told her anything again, about any of it, all the years till she died.

That's how the ear starts. Just a little click. Just helping.

—

The improvements were the injections.

Twice a week to start, Tuesdays and Fridays, in a white room at the back of the barn, by a Steward in gloves who never looked at your face. Then every day. Then the big ones, the ones they did on a table, with straps, where you lay for six hours and listened to your own bones. I don't know what was in them. Growth, the lads said. Strength. Things off the transistor, worked out to the last drop for what a man's body could be made to do if you didn't care how long he lasted. We didn't ask. We'd been told we were too thick to understand it, and we'd started to believe it, and anyway the money was going in.

It hurts. I want to tell you that properly, because nobody does. It hurts all the time. It's hurt every day for eleven years. When you grow that fast, at that age, after you've stopped, your body doesn't know what's happening to it. It thinks it's being pulled apart, and it's right. My knees went first. Then

my back, then my hands. I used to wake up in the night with my jaw locked because the bone had grown in the dark and the muscle hadn't caught up. Lads cried. Big lads, army lads. A bouncer from the Feathers cried every night for a year, on the bunk under mine, not loud, just steady, like a tap left on. Nobody said anything. You don't.

I got to twenty-nine stone. I got to seven foot one. My hands are the size of a coal shovel now. I can lift the front end of a car with one of them, not the back end, the front, the heavy end, and walk with it. I've done it. I've done it for the Owners, on the moor road, in the snow, when a car went off and there was a Steward inside, and I held it up while two other lads got her out, and she didn't say anything to me because she was crying, and that was all right.

I eat ten thousand calories a day. More, some days. If I miss a meal my hands shake.

The lad who'd been a blacksmith died in the second year. His heart. It got too big for him, they said, the way a boiler gets too big for a house. He died sat on the end of his bunk, putting his boots on, and he just stopped, with one boot on, and Kenny had to carry him out, and they took the boot off him first because the boots are kit and kit goes back.

Two hundred and six lads went into the Lines in Brackton the first year. There's ninety-one of us left from that lot. The rest are the young ones. The ones who were born to it.

I'll come to that. I'll come to our Liam. Give me a minute.

—

The Lines are down by the old gasworks, at the bottom of town, where the canal goes under the railway.

They used to be a bus depot. They put walls up inside it and bunks in, and a canteen, and a yard with a fence round it. You go in at the end of shift and you don't come out till the start of the next one. There's no pub. There's no telly. There's no Mags, not the Cat kind, not the pretty ones that the lads in town go home to. We get the Sergeants.

There's a Sergeant in every room. It's a Mag, I suppose — it's the same sort of thing as the pretty ones, the Stewards make them in the same place — but it's got no body to speak of. It's a grey panel on the wall about the size of a gravestone, with a light in it, and a voice. It never stops. That's the thing you have to understand about it. It never, ever stops.

It says: You are slow, and that is all right.

It says: You are strong, and that is what you are for.

It says: The people in the town are your betters. They are clever and they are kind and they are fragile. You will never touch them. You will never raise your voice to them. When they speak to you, you will say sir, and you will say sorry, and you will lower your eyes, because you are a danger to them simply by standing there, and it is not their fault, and it is not your fault, and it is nobody's fault, and you will be grateful.

It says: The Owners love you. The Owners have given you work that matters. Without you there is nothing. With you there is everything. You will never turn on the Owners. You will never think of it. If you think of it, you will tell the Sergeant, and the Sergeant will help you stop.

It says: A Brute who harms a person in the town will be stopped by a Brute. A Brute who turns on the Owners will be stopped by a Brute. You will be that Brute, if you are asked. You will be asked. You will be grateful to be asked, because it means you are trusted.

It says those all night. Not loud. About as loud as a man talking in the next room. It says them in different orders and different words so you can't stop hearing them, the way you stop hearing a clock, and it knows — it always knows — when you've started to stop hearing, and it changes, and it's new again. And the headset says them in the day. And they're in the injections, somehow, I don't know how, but they are; you can feel them go in, a sort of warm click at the back of the head, and afterwards everything the Sergeant says sounds truer.

After about a year you start saying them yourself. In your own head. In your own voice. That's when you know it's working.

I'm slow, and that's all right.

See? I didn't even mean to.

—

Our Liam is nine.

His mam was a lass called Tracy who was in the Lines for a year, in the women's end, before she went. There's not many women. There were a few, early on, rugby lasses, a woman who'd done the strongman on the telly. Most of them didn't last the improvements. Tracy did, and then after Liam she didn't, and I don't talk about that, and the Sergeant says I don't need to, which is a mercy.

They're born to it. That's what I didn't know, when I signed. That it doesn't stop with you. Whatever they put in us goes into the kids, and then they put more in the kids, from little, so it takes better. Liam was born the size of a three-month-old. He was walking at seven months, because his legs were so strong he couldn't not. He gets his jabs on a Tuesday and a

Friday, like his dad did, and the Sergeant in the kids' room is a different voice, a softer one, like a teacher, and it says the same things.

He's a lovely lad. He's funny. He does impressions of the Sergeant when he thinks nobody's listening — You are slow, Liam, and that is all right — in a little posh voice, and the other kids laugh, and I laugh, because I can't help it, and then the Sergeant on the wall says, quite gentle, Liam, and he stops, and he looks at the floor, and he says sorry, and something happens in my chest that is not my heart getting too big, though it might be one day.

He asked me last month what the town was like.

I said it was very nice. I said there were trees by the canal and a market with a hundred kinds of cheese, and a pub called the Crown where I used to go with his Uncle Kenny and his Uncle Gaz, and a man on Mill Street who'd cut your hair and talk the whole way through.

"Can I go?" he said.

And my ear clicked, and the voice said, No, and I said, "You're going, kid. You'll be working in it. You'll be carrying the steel for the new buildings by the canal. Just like your dad."

And he was so pleased. He was so pleased he went round the yard with his arms out like a plane.

—

Right. Wednesday.

I'll tell it in order. I'll try.

Wednesday me and Kenny were on the carry. That's moving heavy kit from the depot at the top end down to wherever it's wanted, and Wednesday it was a cooling unit for the new place on the canal, a steel box about the size of a chest

freezer and about the weight of a small car. Kenny had it up on his shoulder. I walked behind, on the ear. That's how a carry goes: one lifts, one listens.

We came down past the Crown about six, half six. The windows were all lit up and there were lads in the corner under the telly, laughing, and I looked in, the way I always do, because I used to sit there. I know you're not supposed to look. I look anyway, with the side of my eyes. There were three lads in the corner under the telly. One of them had a pint halfway up and he was looking out at us through the glass and he said something, and the others nodded. They looked happy. They looked like we used to look.

There were some lads outside the door having a smoke — they still smoke, some of them, for the feeling, though the transistors fixed it so it doesn't do anything to you now — and one of them called out after us. Mind your head, big man. Oh no, wait. Nothing in it.

That's an old one. We get that one a lot. It's all right. They laugh, and it's all right.

Then Kenny stopped to shift the unit. It was digging into his shoulder plate. And a lad came out of the door, a young lad in a good jacket, and walked right up to him and put his chin about level with Kenny's chest and grinned up at him and said, "Struggling, are we?"

"No, sir," said Kenny.

"Looks like it from here."

"Sorry, sir."

"Thick as mince," said the lad, to nobody, and went off, pleased with himself.

Kenny stood there with his eyes down until he'd gone. Then the ear said move on, and I touched mine, and Kenny

settled the unit, and we went on down the street.

That should have been it. It's nearly always it.

We dropped the unit at the canal. We signed it in. Then we got a second job on the ear, a pallet of blocks up on Kenning Street for the morning, and we were walking up there about nine o'clock, empty-handed, not talking, and the young lad in the good jacket came out of the Feathers on the corner of Kenning Street with two of his mates. He'd had a few more by then. You could see it.

He saw Kenny and his face lit up like Christmas.

"It's him! It's the struggler!"

Kenny stopped. He had to. The lad was in front of him on the pavement and you don't walk round them, you wait.

"How's the shoulder, big man? Shoulder all right, is it?"

"Yes, sir."

"Say it again."

"Yes, sir."

"In a voice. Go on. Do it in a posh voice."

Kenny didn't say anything. His hand went up to his ear. I saw it go.

The lad's mates were laughing. One of them had his phone up. They do that. You end up on their phones and the phones show it to everybody else who'll laugh, and the transistors learn that people like to laugh at Brutes, and there's more of it, and that's all right. That's what we're for. Partly.

"You're not even listening," said the lad. "Are you? What's in there? Eh?" And he reached up, a long way up, and tapped on Kenny's headset with one finger. Tap tap. "Hello? Anybody home?"

Then he poured his pint over Kenny's head.

He had to go on his tiptoes to do it. It went down Kenny's face and into his eyes and down the neck of his kit, and his mates were nearly on the floor, and the lad stood back and looked up at him, very pleased, and said:

"There you go. Now you've had a drink in the Crown."

I don't know what it was. I've thought about it every minute since and I don't know. I've had worse. Kenny had had worse. Kenny had a lad set his kit on fire once, in 2031, for a dare, and Kenny stood there and let it burn out and said sorry, sir. I think it was the Crown. I think it was him saying the Crown. Because we used to drink there. Because it was ours, before. I don't know.

Kenny took him by the jacket.

That's all he did. I want you to know that. I want you to know exactly what he did, because it matters to me that somebody knows. He took the lad by the front of his good jacket with one hand and lifted him up, not fast, not rough, just up, until the lad's feet were off the pavement and his face was level with Kenny's face, and then he put him against the wall of the Feathers, quite gentle, the way you'd hang a coat. And he held him there. And he looked at him. That was all. He didn't hit him. He didn't squeeze. He didn't say anything. He just held him up there on the wall and looked at him, with the beer still running down his face, for about two seconds.

I think he just wanted the lad to see him. I think that's all it was. I think he wanted, for two seconds, to be looked at, eye to eye, by one of them.

The lad screamed.

And my ear said: Walsh. Doyle. Now.

—

I'm going to tell you this the way it happened. I'm not going to make it nicer, because it wasn't, and I'm not going to make it worse, because it was quick, and I made it quick, and that's the one thing I did that was mine.

The voice in the ear isn't like a voice when it's an order. It's like your own arm moving. You don't decide. You're already doing it before you've heard the end of it. Eleven years of the Sergeant every night, and the jabs, and the warm click, and it all comes down to that: your own arm moving before you've heard the end of the word.

I took Kenny from behind.

I got my right arm round his neck and my left hand on the back of his head, the way they taught us in the barn, the way I'd learned in the army before that and never once used on a man. He let go of the lad. He let go straight away. The lad dropped down the wall on to the pavement and scrabbled off on his backside, still screaming. Kenny didn't fight me. That's the bit. He could have. He was as big as me. If he'd fought me it would have taken a long time, and it would have been on all their phones, and everybody in Brackton would have seen what two of us look like when we're not being sorry.

He didn't fight. His hands came up and took hold of my arm — not to pull it off, just to hold on to it, like a man on a bus holding the rail — and he said, "Darren," just once, quite quiet. Not asking for anything. Just saying my name. The way you'd say it to somebody you'd seen across a room.

I turned my arms.

You know the sound. You've heard it in films. It's not like the films. It's lower than that, and wetter, and you feel it more than you hear it, all the way up your arms and into your chest, like a door going in a house you're standing in.

Then he was heavy.

I held him up for a bit. I don't know why. I didn't want him to go down on the pavement in the beer. Then I couldn't, and I let him down, slowly, on to his side, and I put his arm under his head, which was stupid, because he didn't need it.

The lad in the good jacket was sitting against the wall with his legs out. He'd wet himself. His mates had stopped laughing. One of them still had his phone up, but his hand was shaking so much it was no good to anybody.

The ear said: Good. Stand by.

I stood by.

—

Nobody came.

That's the thing I want to tell you about, more than the rest. Nobody came. There used to be police. There still are, I think, somewhere, for the Cat people, for their little bits of bother. Nobody came for this. Nobody was going to. It wasn't a crime. You can't murder a Brute. There's no law about it, one way or the other, because the law's for people.

The lad got up after a bit. His mate helped him. He looked down at his trousers, and then at Kenny on the pavement, and then up at me, and I lowered my eyes, because you do. And he said — and his voice was all wobbly, like a kid's — he said:

"Well, he shouldn't have kicked off."

"No, sir," I said.

"You all saw. He went for me."

"Yes, sir."

And they went. They went off up Kenning Street, the three of them, and halfway up one of them laughed — just a sort of hiccup of a laugh, the way you laugh when you've had a fright

and you're all right after all — and then the other two laughed as well, and by the top of the street they were laughing properly. I heard them go round the corner. I heard one of them say, Did you see his face, though?

I don't know whose face he meant.

A Mag came out of a side street, one of the little ones, the kind that does the drains, and went to work on the beer on the pavement. Very careful. Round Kenny, not under him. It didn't know what he was. It just knew where the mess was.

Then Gaz came.

The ear had sent him. You never get the one who does it to carry them on his own. They send a second. They always send somebody you know, which I used to think was cruel and now I think is the only kindness in it, because who else would you want.

Gaz Marsh came down Kenning Street at a run, which we don't do, and stopped, and looked at Kenny on the pavement with his arm under his head. Gaz has got grey stubble and a line between his eyebrows that's been getting deeper since about 2030, and I watched it go deeper while I stood there.

He didn't say anything for a long time.

Then he said, "Why'd you kill him like that?"

Not why. Like that. He knew why.

"Because I have to," I said.

"You didn't have to do it like that, though. Darren. You could have —"

"It was quick."

"I know it was quick."

"If it wasn't like that it wouldn't have been quick. He'd have — if it wasn't quick he'd have had time to fight. And then they'd have had to send more of us. And then —"

I stopped, because the ear clicked, and the voice said something about not speculating, and I didn't have to say the rest. Gaz knew the rest. Every one of us knows the rest. If two Brutes fight in the street and it goes on long enough for the town to see, then the town sees, and then the town knows what we are, and then there's a day after that, and nobody wants that day. Not the Owners. Not the Stewards. Not the lads in the Crown. Not us. Not even us. The Sergeant's made very sure of that. Not even us.

Gaz looked at me for a long time with the line between his eyebrows.

"I know," he said. "I know you do."

Then we picked Kenny up between us, one at each end, the way you'd carry a beam, and we carried him down Kenning Street and over the canal and down past the gasworks to the Lines. People got out of our way. People always get out of our way. A woman with a pram crossed over, and a car slowed down to look and then didn't, and a couple coming out of the theatre in the old dye works stood back against the wall with their arms round each other and watched us go by and didn't say anything.

At the Lines we took his kit off him first. Kit goes back.

—

That night the Sergeant was very kind to me.

It said: You did well, Darren.

It said: You did what was asked. You were quick. You were merciful. You kept the town safe and you kept the Owners safe and you kept every Brute in Brackton safe, because if you had not done it, it would have had to be done anyway, by

somebody else, and slower, and more of us would have been lost.

It said: Kenneth Doyle was a good man who made one mistake. You are a good man who made none.

It said: You are slow, and that is all right. You are strong, and that is what you are for. You are trusted. You are trusted more than anyone in this room.

And I lay on my bunk with my hands on my chest, and my hands still had the feel of it in them, the door going in the house, and I listened to it saying all of that in its voice like the shipping forecast, and the worst thing — I want to tell you this, I want somebody to know this — the worst thing was that it helped. It did. I lay there and it went in, warm, like the click after a jab, and I felt it go in, and I felt better. I felt trusted. I felt proud.

I said thank you to it. Out loud. In the dark. I didn't decide to.

And it said, You're welcome, Darren, and I slept.

Over in the kids' end, through the wall, I could hear Liam's Sergeant going too. The softer one. I couldn't hear the words. But it was the same tune.

—

Thursday morning the ear said: Walsh. Ashcombe. Gate.

That's a good posting. That's the best there is. You only get the gate if you're trusted, and you only get it after something, and everybody in the Lines knows what the something usually is, and nobody says. Gaz was in the canteen when I went through with my kit. He didn't look up. He was on the canal frame that day. He'd have the steel beams, and the cold, and the lads on the towpath. I'd have the gate, and the trees, and

the moor, and once a day the man with the long face walking down the drive with his dog to say good morning to us.

I'd rather have had the beams. I don't know if that's allowed. I'm telling you anyway.

The food's better at Ashcombe. I'll say that. At Ashcombe we get beef. Proper beef, the best there is, off the Owners' own table, every day, a great thick slice of it on the tin plate at the end of the shift, pink all through. He sees to that himself. He's told them. Whatever the best is, the lads on the gate get it. It's the kindest thing anybody does for us and it's the only kind thing, and I ate it Thursday dinner standing up by the gatepost, with the feel of Kenny's neck still in my hands, and it was beautiful. It was the best thing I've ever eaten. I wanted to be sick.

In the afternoon a car came up from the town. Black, quiet. A Steward.

I went down to the window and bent down and it was a young woman, posh-looking, with her hair pinned up and a pale coat on and her hands in her lap where I could see them. They all do that. The Stewards. They put their hands where you can see them. They don't know they do it. It used to make me want to laugh, and then it made me want to cry, and now it doesn't make me want anything.

"Cassie May," she said. "From the Assay. I'm expected."

The ear said she was. I opened the gate.

And she said thank you.

To me. She looked up at me through the window and she said, "Thank you," the way you'd say it to the man on Mill Street when he's finished your hair.

Nobody's said thank you to me in eleven years. Nobody. Not once. I say it. I say it every night to the Sergeant and

every day to the lads in the town who tell me I'm thick, and I say it to the Owners, and I say it in my own head when I don't mean to. But nobody's said it to me.

I stopped. I didn't mean to. My hand was on the gate and it just stopped.

And for about one second I was a scaffolder on Mill Street in 2027 with a flat over the bookies and a girl called Donna who said I had kind eyes for a big lad. I could feel the wind on the scaffold. I could hear the football on somebody's radio, three floors down. I was seventeen stone and my knees didn't hurt and I had never killed anybody, and a woman was saying thank you to me, and I was going to say, you're welcome, love, the way you would.

Then the ear clicked.

It didn't say anything. It didn't need to. It just clicked, very gently, the way you'd tap a lad on the shoulder at a funeral when he's started laughing.

I put my eyes down on the gravel.

"Ma'am," I said.

The car went through. She looked back at me in the mirror. I saw her. I didn't look back.

When she came down again at four I opened the gate again and she didn't say it that time. She just looked at me. I looked at her for about a quarter of a second, which is a long time, for us. Then the ear clicked and I looked at the gravel and she was gone.

That night the Sergeant in the gatehouse said: The Stewards are kind. Their kindness is not for you. Do not mistake it for something that is for you.

And I said thank you.

And I lay there in the dark at Ashcombe with my hands on my chest and the beef sitting in me like a stone and the moor wind going round the gatehouse, and I thought about her saying it. Thank you. Just like that. Like it was nothing. Like I was somebody you'd say it to.

I'm slow, and that's all right.

I'm strong, and that's what I'm for.

I'm telling you this so you know where you are.

CHAPTER SIX

Sterling Bronson got up at five, because at sixty-three that was when his body got him up, and went to look at Brackton through the telescope.

It was in the little room at the top of the house, under the slates, where the servants had slept two hundred years ago. It was a good telescope. It was the best telescope there was, because he had asked the Clerk for the best, and when Sterling asked for the best of something the Clerk had a habit of taking him at his word. It stood on three brass legs at the window, pointed down the long fall of the moor towards the town, and on a clear morning, with the mist off the canal, you could read the clock on the front of the Assay Office from here. You could see the queue at the bakery. You could see, if you were patient, the barber on Mill Street put his sign out.

He was patient. He had all the time in the world. That was, by some distance, the strangest thing about being him.

He put his eye to it.

The Mags were out. He watched one of them on the corner of Kenning Street, treading in round a sapling, and he looked

away from Kenning Street quite quickly. He found the market instead. Garside's shutter was still down. He found the Crown, dark and shut, with a cat asleep on the step, and the canal with the new building half up beside it, the steel frame black against the water, and a Brute already on the frame, alone, at five in the morning, sitting with his legs over the drop and his hand at his ear.

He watched the Brute for a long time.

Then he found the ridge road, and followed it up past the reservoir to the Rise, and found the house with the long lawn and the piano under its sheet, which he could not see but knew was there, and watched a light come on in an upstairs window. Ten to six. Cassie, awake on her own, the old way. He smiled. He liked to know she was up.

"You're doing it again," said the Clerk, from the stairs.

"Doing what?"

"Looking at it."

"It's mine," said Sterling. "I'm allowed to look at it."

"It is not yours," said the Clerk. "You have been very clear on that point in the past. You said, and I have it here, that it belongs to the people in it, and you merely keep it running."

"I was on the telly when I said that."

"You said it again in March. In the bath."

Sterling took his eye off the telescope.

"I wish I'd never given you ears," he said, and went down to put the kettle on.

—

The Clerk was the only Mag at Ashcombe, and he had made it himself, in the second year, on this kitchen table, with a Steward from the first intake holding the torch. Everybody

else in the country had a Mag that had learned them. Sterling had built one that had learned the figures. Every figure. Every board from every Assay in every town, and the coil, and the Lines, and the long numbers underneath all of it that nobody but the seven of them ever saw. He had made it the shape of a filing cabinet so that he would never once be tempted to love it, and he had given it the voice of a tired accountant because that was the voice he trusted most in the world, from his childhood, when his father had done the books for a builders' merchant on the kitchen table every Sunday night and had never once, in eighteen years, told him a comforting lie.

He had set it up to disagree with him. That was all it was for. It was the most expensive thing in the house and its only job was to tell him, every day, at least once, that he was wrong.

It was the one Mag in the country that wasn't pleasant to be around. It had been his idea of a joke at first, a small private penance. Now he couldn't have lived without it. The others had theirs — Helen had a thing like a weather vane that hummed when she was being sentimental, and the Pryce brothers shared one that did nothing but play them their own old speeches back until they winced — but none of them had gone quite as far as the Clerk, and none of them, Sterling privately felt, slept quite as well.

He made the tea. He let the dog in. He sat at the burnt pine table in his dressing gown and the Clerk read him the overnight, the whole country's, in its flat grey voice, and he listened with his eyes shut.

The country had picked a little under a hundred million times in the night. It was happy. It was, by every measure anybody had ever thought of, the happiest it had been since any-

one had started measuring. Nobody was hungry. Nobody was cold. Nobody waited in a corridor for four hours with a bad chest. In Brackton alone, the Clerk said, three hundred and four thousand people had gone to sleep last night and woken up in a house that was warm, and theirs, with a Mag in it who knew exactly how they liked their tea. The infirmary had been quiet. The Assay had been quiet. The turn against yellow cars had got as far as the canal.

"Poor yellow," said Sterling.

"That is what she said," said the Clerk.

And underneath the happiness, because there was always an underneath, there were the other figures. The Lines. Ninety-one men left in Brackton from the first year, out of two hundred and six. A boy of nine with a heart already eleven per cent larger than the transistors would have liked. Four hundred and forty Brutes asleep in the old bus depot by the gasworks, with a grey panel on the wall of every room, saying, all night, in a voice like the shipping forecast, what they were for.

And one flag, eight days old now, from Kenning Street.

"Read it," said Sterling.

"You have read it."

"Read it again."

The Clerk read it again. It was very short. A time, a street, two numbers, two names. Doyle, Kenneth. Walsh, Darren. And underneath, the only line the Clerk ever added to a flag of that kind, because Sterling had asked it to, years ago, and it did not forget: Done quickly.

Sterling sat with his eyes shut and his hands round the mug.

“I shook his hand,” he said. “Doyle. In the barn. I remember. He had a tattoo of a swallow on his thumb.”

“You say that every time.”

“Because it’s true every time.”

The dog put its head on his knee. He put his hand on the dog.

“We’re living life how it makes sense,” said Sterling Bronson, to nobody, which was who he said it to most mornings. “That’s all. That’s all we’re doing. Living it how it makes sense.”

“Yes,” said the Clerk. “It does make sense.”

It was not, strictly, disagreeing with him. But it was the way it said it.

—

It had started, as far as Sterling was concerned, in a car park.

Not the transistors themselves — the transistors had started long before that, in a dozen places at once, the way these things do, with a great many clever people arguing in rooms. He had been one of them. So had Helen, and the Pryce brothers, and Ruth, and the twins, who were not really twins but had been called that since university and never shaken it. Between them they had come to own the transistors, by the end, and the coil that the transistors ran on, the way you might come to own a river by buying a field on either side of it and then waking up one day to find that everybody drank from it.

But the thing itself — the shape of it, the way it all worked now — that had started in a car park, in 2026, outside a supermarket on the ring road, when he had been sitting in his

car waiting for Ruth and watching a man in his fifties try to choose between two kinds of tinned tomatoes.

The man had stood there for six minutes. Sterling had timed him. He had picked up one tin and then the other and then the first again, and held them side by side in the cold under the trolley shelter, and turned them to the light, and frowned. And then, with a little decisive nod, he had picked. And put the other one back. And gone off to his car, satisfied, with a tin of tomatoes that was in every measurable way identical to the one he hadn't chosen.

"That," Sterling had said to Ruth, when she got in, "is the one thing they can't do."

"Who can't do what?"

"The transistors. They can do everything. They can do medicine, and law, and the accounts, and they can write a better song than anybody alive. They'll be able to drive this car by Christmas. But they can't do that." He had pointed. "They don't want anything. They'll never want anything. They can't stand under a trolley shelter in the cold for six minutes and care which tin. Only he can do that."

Ruth had looked at the man getting into his car.

"So?"

"So that's the job," Sterling had said. "That's everybody's job, from now on. Caring which tin."

She had laughed at him. Then she had stopped laughing, somewhere around the second roundabout, and by the time they got home she had stopped talking altogether, and that night the seven of them had sat up till four in Helen's kitchen, and in the morning there were Cats.

That was the joke of it. That was the thing he had never once been able to say on the telly, all through 2027, every

night, with the whole frightened country looking at him and asking what about our jobs. The transistors could do everything except want. And wanting, it turned out, was the most valuable thing in the world. It was the only thing the transistors needed from anybody. Not skill. Not cleverness. Not years of training or a good degree or a queue outside your door. Just a person standing in the cold caring which tin, eight hours a day, a few hundred times an hour, and the transistors learning from every single one of them. Everybody had it. A grandmother had it. A man choosing between two snowflakes had it, and took it seriously. It was the one thing that would never be automated, because the moment you automated it there would be no point to any of the rest.

So they had paid people to want things. A proper wage, at first, in ordinary money, so nobody would be frightened. And then the scores. And then, gently, over years, the money going out like a tide, until nobody could remember the last time they had paid for anything. And it had worked. It had worked better than anything had ever worked. It was working this morning, in every front room in Brackton, as the town woke up and put the kettle on and sat down at its screens and began, with tremendous seriousness, to care.

That was the bright half.

—

The dark half had started in the barn.

Not the day he had walked along the benches shaking hands, the day he had told a scaffolder called Walsh that everything they were going to build would sit on the back of men like him, and meant it. Before that. A month before. A Monday in September 2027, when the seven of them had sat

round the long table in the barn with the first Clerk — a rough thing, then, just a voice in a box — and asked it the question none of them wanted to ask.

Who guards it?

The coil. The transistors. The houses on the Rise, and the Assay in every town, and this house, and the seven of them in it. Because there would be very few of them. That was the shape of the thing. Eight in ten people would care which tin. A very few would keep the transistors learning. And a handful, seven, would own the whole of it, and the coil it ran on, and everything that came out of the end. And that was all right; that was how it had to be; somebody had to keep it running, and there was nobody else who could. But there would be so very few of them. And somebody would have to lift. Somebody would have to carry what the Mags couldn't, and build what the Mags couldn't, and stand at the gate. Somebody would have to be strong.

And whoever was strong could take it.

The Clerk had told them. In the voice. It had told them that if the strong were simply strong, and paid, and left alone, then sooner or later — in eleven years, it said, or nine, or fourteen, it gave them the whole curve — they would notice. Not out of malice. Out of arithmetic. They would notice that there were a great many of them and very few of everybody else at the top, and that they were the ones holding the building up. And they would take it. And they would not know how to run it, because nobody did, except the seven and the Stewards. And the coil would stop. And the transistors would stop. And every front room in the country would go cold and dark at once, and the infirmary would stop, and the food would stop, and the Mags would stop where they stood, and three hundred

thousand people in Brackton alone would wake up one morning back in 2026, without the skills they'd had then, because nobody needed those any more.

The Clerk gave them the number of people who would die in the first winter. Sterling remembered it. He had never told anybody it, and never would.

"So they can't be just strong," Helen had said, at last. "They've got to be —"

She hadn't finished. Nobody had finished. The Clerk had finished for them, in its box, in its voice, and they had sat round the table in the barn and listened to it describe what would have to be done to a man to make him strong enough to hold up the world and certain, all the way down, that he must never once put it down. The injections. The ear. The panel on the wall that never stopped. The children. It had all been there, that first afternoon, worked out to the last decimal, like a set of accounts.

And they had sat there. Seven of the cleverest people in the country. And not one of them had been able to find the mistake in it.

They had tried for a month. Sterling had tried hardest. He had sat up every night of that September, at this table, with the box, asking it again and again, looking for the gap. Couldn't the Mags do it? No; not for years; perhaps never. Couldn't they pay them more? Yes; it didn't help; it made the curve worse. Couldn't they just be decent to them? Yes; they should be; they must be; and it would not, the box said, make the slightest difference to the arithmetic. Couldn't they ask the Cat people to do it, everybody, in turns? And the box had said: Look at them. And he had looked at them, on the telly, the office lads going white round the mouth, the frightened,

the clever, the soft, and he had known that they couldn't. That they would go mad. That the very thing that made them so good at caring which tin would break them in a week on the gate.

At the end of the month he had gone down to the barn and shaken sixty hands.

He had known, every one of them. He had looked up at a scaffolder called Walsh and known exactly what he was shaking hands with, and what he was going to do to it, and he had said, I won't forget. And he hadn't. That was the only promise he had made in the barn that he had been able to keep. He had not forgotten. Not one of them. Not the blacksmith with one boot on. Not the bouncer from the Feathers who cried every night for a year. Not Doyle, with the swallow on his thumb.

It made sense. That was the horror of it, if there was a horror. It wasn't that it was cruel. It was that it was right. It was the only way the whole of it could work, and the whole of it was so very good, and so very many people were warm this morning because of it, that there was simply no argument left on the other side except a feeling. And a feeling was not an argument. He had built the most rational thing the world had ever seen. You couldn't then go and put a feeling in the middle of it, like a brick in a washing machine, just because you couldn't sleep.

So he didn't sleep. That was his end of it. That was what he'd told Cassie at the kitchen table: you don't need to look; that's ours.

—

They had stopped going on the telly in the spring of 2028.

People thought it was sinister. Sterling's own mother had thought so; she had rung him in tears to ask whether he'd been done in, and he had had to drive round and sit in her front room for an hour to prove that he hadn't. It wasn't sinister. It was the Cats.

By the spring of 2028 nearly everything on the telly was made of what people had picked, and the transistors had begun, in the ordinary way, to show the seven of them where they stood. Every night they went on, and talked about the future, and every night the country was quietly given the choice, in a hundred small ways, between watching them and watching something else. And in March the Clerk — the second Clerk, the one with the accountant's voice — had read them the figures.

The country preferred them to the news, narrowly. It preferred them to the weather. It did not prefer them to the football, and it did not prefer them to a programme about a woman on the coast who rescued donkeys, and it did not, by a margin of ninety-four to six, prefer them to a programme about a dog.

"What sort of dog?" said one of the twins.

"A Labrador," said the Clerk. "It is very good with children."

There had been a short silence round the table in the barn.

"Well," Sterling had said. "That's us told."

And they had stopped. That was all. Nobody had made them. Nobody had wanted them gone. It was simply that the telly was made of what people wanted now, and what people wanted, when it came to it, was the dog. Nobody hated them. Nobody ever had, really. People had been frightened of them, which was different, and then people had stopped being

frightened, and once you were no longer frightened of a man there was not much reason to watch him talk.

But the face stayed. That was the thing they hadn't thought about. The face had been on every screen in the country every night for a year and a half, at the most frightening time anybody could remember, and it had gone in deep, the way a song from that kind of year goes in. Ten years on, there was not a person in Brackton who wouldn't have known him from the back of his head. If he walked down Mill Street they would stop. All of them. They wouldn't mean any harm. They'd want to say hello. They'd want to tell him about their jobs, and their Mags, and how much better it all was, and thank you, and could they have a picture, and was it true about the dog. They'd come out of the cafés and the barber's and the market, two hundred, five hundred, a thousand of them, warm and delighted and pressing in, the way crowds do, and somewhere at the back of the crowd somebody would push, and somewhere at the front of it somebody would fall.

And there would be Brutes there. Because there were always Brutes there, wherever he went. And a Brute in a crowd that was pressing on an Owner had an order in his ear for that, too.

So he didn't go. It wasn't that he couldn't. There was no law. He could have told the car the Crown this morning, and the car would have taken him. It was only that he had worked it out, the way he worked everything out, and the arithmetic said that the safest thing for everybody, the kindest thing for everybody, was for the most recognisable man in the country to stay at the top of the moor with his dog, and look at it all through a telescope.

He had been looking at it for ten years. He knew the bakery queue by sight. He knew the barber's sign. He had watched the Crown's windows light up at six o'clock every evening for a decade, and never once been inside.

He would have liked a pint in the Crown. He would have liked it very much. He thought about it more than he thought about almost anything, and the Clerk knew it, and very kindly never mentioned it, which was the only thing it had ever done for him that could have been called kind.

—

At nine he put his boots on and took the dog down the drive to the gate.

He did this every day. It was a mile there and back between the old trees, and the dog liked it, and the lads on the gate liked it, or he hoped they did, and he liked it more than either of them. It was the only part of the day when he was looking at a human face that wasn't on a screen or Cassie's.

There were four of them on the gate. He knew them all by name. He said good morning to each of them, and each of them said, "Sir," and lowered their eyes, and he talked to them about the weather and the football and the dog, the way you would, and they answered him in the way they had, short and soft and careful, like men handling something fragile, which in a sense they were.

Walsh was at the end. He looked tired. They all looked tired. But Walsh looked tired in a particular way that Sterling knew, because he saw it every morning in the bathroom mirror.

"Walsh."

"Sir."

“Walk with me a bit. Down to the wall. The dog wants a look at the sheep.”

The ear must have said it was all right, because Walsh came. They went along the inside of the wall together, the old man and the dog and the Brute, the Brute a careful half-step behind and to the side, the way they were taught, so that his shadow wouldn’t fall on anybody. It fell on Sterling anyway. There was no way for it not to. It was like walking in the shade of a building.

“How are you sleeping?”

“Well, sir. Thank you.”

“No, you’re not.”

Walsh said nothing. His hand had gone up to his ear.

“It’s all right,” said Sterling. “You can leave that. I’m telling you you’re not, because I’m not either. That’s all. I know what you did. I read it. I read it every morning.”

They walked. The dog put its nose through a gap in the wall and barked at a sheep, and the sheep looked at it with contempt.

“It says you did it quickly,” said Sterling. “I asked them to put that in, years ago. If it was quick. I wanted to know.”

“Yes, sir.”

“That was decent of you. I want you to know I know that. That was the decentest thing anyone could have done, in that street, that night, and it was you that did it.”

Walsh did not say anything for a long time. They came to the corner of the wall, where you could see down the whole long fall of the moor to the town in its valley, small and lit and perfect, like something under glass.

Then the Brute said, very quietly, looking at the town:

“Is there anything else I could do, sir?”

Sterling turned.

"Anything," said Walsh. His voice had gone strange. He wasn't looking at the gravel. He was looking at the town. "Not the gate. Not the carry. I don't mind what. I could do Cats. I know football. I used to know football. I could — I could do the drains. I don't mind. I could go in with the Mags and do the drains. I'd be good at it. I'd be quiet. Nobody'd know I was there. Is there anything else? Anything at all?"

His hand had come down from his ear. It was hanging by his side, enormous, the fingers moving a little, opening and closing, as though they were looking for something to hold on to.

Sterling looked up at him. The face. The whole country's face, gone grey at the edges, looking up a long way into the face of a man he had shaken hands with in a barn.

He wanted to say yes. He had never wanted anything as much in his life, not the pint in the Crown, not anything. He wanted to say yes, of course, there's the drains, there's the Cats, there's a house on the Rise and a pretty Mag and a long soft slope down into sleep, take your boy and go. He could have said it. There was nobody to stop him. He owned the whole of it.

And he could see, behind his own eyes, the Clerk's curve. The one from the barn. What happens when one of them goes down into the town and sits at a screen and is happy. What the other four hundred and thirty-nine in the Lines would make of that. What they would notice. How soon.

"No," said Sterling Bronson gently. "No, lad. I'm sorry. You already know too much."

The Brute stood very still.

Then his hand went back up to his ear, slowly, the way a man puts a hat back on after a funeral. And his eyes went down to the gravel. And he said, "Yes, sir. Sorry, sir," in the soft careful voice, and the strange thing had gone out of it entirely, as if it had never been there.

Sterling stood with him at the corner of the wall for a long time, looking down at the town. He had a great deal more he wanted to say. He had had it ready for eight days. He found, standing there, that he could not get to the front of it, and that if he did he wouldn't be able to stop, and that the man beside him was not, this morning, able to bear being told any of it.

Another day, he thought. When it would help.

"Come on," he said. "The dog's had enough of the sheep. Let's get you back."

—

That afternoon he sat at the burnt pine table and could not eat his lunch.

It was beef. Of course it was beef. Garside's rib, dark outside and pink all through, in the black tin, the best thing in Brackton. He looked at it on his plate and thought about the lads on the gate eating it off tin plates, standing up, at the end of a twelve-hour shift, and about a man asking whether there was anything else he could do and being told no.

"Clerk."

"Yes."

"The beef. For the gate."

"They are getting it. As you asked. In April, and three times since, with increasing emphasis."

"Double it."

The Clerk was quiet for a moment, which it did not often do.

"Double it," it said. "And not only the gate. The Lines."

"The Lines. All of them. The canal lads, the carry, the frame, all of them. The kids. Whatever the best is. Every one of them gets the best there is, every day, from now on. It's the least —" He stopped. "It's very nearly the only thing. So we do it."

"The best there is," said the Clerk, "is Garside's aged rib. There is only so much of it. Doubling the gate and adding the Lines will take all of it."

"All of what?"

"All of the aged rib in Brackton."

Sterling put down his knife.

"Then all of it," he said.

"There will be none for anyone else."

"There's plenty else. There's always plenty else. There's lamb. There's chicken. There's pork, isn't there, and ten kinds of sausage. Nobody's going without. Nobody in Brackton has gone without anything in nine years." He pushed the plate away. "A few people won't get a particular cut of beef for a while. Well. Let them have the chicken. The lads on that gate held a car up in the snow."

The Clerk considered this.

"You are wrong," it said at last, "about one thing."

"Go on."

"It will not be a few people. It will be a very small number of people who want that particular cut of beef very much."

"And?"

"And they will not know why they cannot have it," said the Clerk. "It will not be in their scores. They will pick well, and

pick better, and it still will not come. Nothing they do will bring it back. They will simply find, every evening, that it is not there."

Sterling thought about this. He thought about it honestly, the way he had thought about the curve in the barn.

"Will it hurt them?"

"No."

"Will it make them unhappy?"

The Clerk ran it. It took a little while.

"Mildly puzzled," it said. "For a period. One of them in particular. He is very fond of it."

"Mildly puzzled," said Sterling Bronson, and for the first time that day, he laughed. "Well, I think the country can stand that. Don't you? I think the country can survive one man in Brackton being mildly puzzled about his tea."

He pulled the plate back towards him, and found he could eat after all.

"All of it," he said again, with his mouth full. "To the Lines. Every day. Starting tonight."

And the Clerk, which existed to disagree with him, and had just done so, and been overruled, said, "Yes," in its flat grey voice, and saw to it.

That evening, in the little room under the slates, he put his eye to the telescope and found the old bus depot by the gasworks. It was dark, as it always was, apart from the canteen. He watched the lads coming in off the shift, one after another, huge and slow, through the yard gate, and he watched the lights in the canteen for a long time, and imagined them sitting down at the long tables, every one of them, the boy of nine as well, with a great thick slice of the best thing in Brackton on a tin plate in front of them.

It was not enough. He knew it was not enough. It was not anything like enough.

But it was what there was. So he did it.

Down in the town, in a long low silver car on its way home from the Crown, a man in a good mood looked at the little screen in the door, scrolled past the curries and the pies and the fish with a particular, hopeful purpose, and found that the rib of beef was not there.

"Huh," said Reed.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The beef did not come back on the Friday.

Reed noticed this in the way he noticed the weather: as a fact about the day, mildly interesting, nothing to do with him. He had been the very picture of a football man all week. He had picked for the room. He had picked, if anything, more for the room than the room deserved, and the Crown had been a happy place every night, and every night when he came through the door Charleston had looked up and said, "Here he is. Captain Football," and the pint that arrived had been the exact shade he liked. His figures were the best they had been since March. He had very nearly forgotten what a dive looked like.

And on the Friday he scrolled down past the curries and the pies and the fish, and the rib of beef was not there.

He looked again, the way you look in a cupboard.

There was other beef. That was the odd bit. There was mince, and a nice-looking brisket, and some steaks that he would happily have eaten on any other night of the year. There was pork. There was lamb. There were ten kinds of

sausage. It was only the rib that had gone — the one from the wedding, the one Garside did something to that Reed didn't understand and didn't need to — and it had not gone grey, the way it had on the Monday and the Tuesday before the extra Cats. It had simply gone. There wasn't even the little picture.

"Huh," he said.

He had the lamb. It was very good.

On the Saturday it wasn't there either. He did an extra set of Cats on the Sunday morning, out of habit, the way his dad had always put a bet on when the horses were running whether or not he fancied anything, and he gave them his full attention, and on the Sunday night it still wasn't there. Nor Monday. Nor Tuesday. On the Wednesday he took a recommendation that came up in the corner of his screen — an extra hour of football for a meat credit, the same as before — and did it, and did it well, and was given a meat credit, and went to look, and the meat credit was sitting there on the screen next to a list of every kind of meat in Brackton except the one he wanted, like a man at a dance who has got all dressed up and finds the only girl he came for has gone home.

He was not upset. It would be wrong to call it upset. He had had beef the Friday before, and the Wednesday before that, and he had had very good lamb since, and a chicken thing with lemon in it that Grace had done twice now and which was, in fairness, excellent. Nobody in Brackton went without anything. It was only that it was odd. It was only that he had always known, his whole life, roughly how a thing worked even if he didn't know how it worked, the way you know roughly where the sun will come up. You picked well, and the good things came. You picked badly, and they took a

little while. Then you picked well again, and back they came, as though they had only nipped out.

This was the first time anything had nipped out and not come back. He found it puzzling. Mildly. The way you'd find it puzzling if a bus that had come at ten past every hour for ten years started coming at twenty past.

He mentioned it to Grace on the Wednesday night.

She was on the sofa with her feet up, and she looked at him, and at the bag, which had sausages in it, and her face did the right thing, the way it always did.

"Still no rib?"

"Still no rib."

"Oh, love."

He sat down. She settled against his shoulder. And he waited, the way he always waited, without knowing he was waiting, for her to say the thing — the thing that would turn it over, so lightly he wouldn't feel her do it, and leave him on his own coming round to a view.

She didn't say anything.

After a while he looked at her.

She was looking at the telly, which was off. She had a small line between her eyebrows that he had never seen there before, in eleven years, and she was quiet in a way he didn't recognise — not the quiet of a woman letting you work something out, but the quiet of a woman who has looked in the cupboard too.

"I don't know, love," said Grace.

He had never heard her say it. Not once. Not about anything.

Then she turned and smiled at him, and it was her own smile, all the way through, and the line had gone. "But I'll tell

you what," she said. "If anybody in this town's going to get his beef back, it's you."

"It is me," Reed agreed, cheered.

"Course it is. Come here."

And there was the lamp, and the warm dark, and her hand on his back, and the long soft slope, and he did not think about it again until he woke up, and even then only a bit.

—

The thing was the Saturday.

On the Saturday it was Brackton Rovers at home to Calder, which happened twice a year and was the only match in the calendar that the whole of the Crown cared about equally. The transistors made the football; everybody knew that; it was all picked, every corner and throw-in and goalkeeper falling over twice. But the Rovers and Calder had been playing each other since 1889, long before anybody picked anything, and there was a feeling about it that no amount of picking had managed to take out. People sang. People who never sang at anything sang. Benjamin had once cried at a Calder game, in 2034, at a header in the eighty-ninth minute, and had denied it ever since with such force that it had become the most famous thing about him.

And for the Calder game, since about 2031, the lads had always had the rib.

It had started with Reed, and he was quietly proud of it. One Calder Saturday he had had the rib on a board in the corner under the telly, pink in the middle and charred at the edges, and Charleston had looked at it and said, "What's that?" and Reed had said, "That's the rib," and given him a bit, and Charleston had gone very quiet and then ordered one

himself, and then Benjamin had, and by the second half half the Crown was on it. Now it was the done thing. Calder Saturday, you had the rib. Garside sent it down on boards. People came in early to make sure.

You could not do the Calder game on chicken. Reed was clear on that. It was not a matter of being upset. It was a matter of how things were done. You could do a Tuesday on chicken. You could do most of the season on chicken, if it came to it. But not Calder. Calder on chicken would be like a wedding in a tracksuit.

He said so in the Crown, on the Thursday night.

"You'll get it," said Charleston, comfortably. "It'll be back Saturday. It always comes back."

"It's been a week."

"Has it?" Benjamin looked up. "Are you sure?"

"A week Friday."

"Have you been picking dives again?"

"I have not been picking dives. I have been picking like a saint. I've been picking like the Pope's doing football. Ask him." He nodded at Charleston. "Who is it every night?"

"It's been him every night," said Charleston, fairly.

"Captain Football," said Benjamin. "Every night."

"Captain Football. And still no rib."

There was a pause round the table while the three of them considered this. It was not quite worry. They did not have the shape for worry any more; it had gone out of them years ago, like the shape for queuing. It was more the sort of pause you get when somebody tells you their clock's been going backwards.

"Huh," said Benjamin.

"That's what I said."

"Have you tried the extra?"

"I've done four extras. I've got that many meat credits I could open a farm."

"Have you asked Garside?"

"Garside says it's not on his side. He says it's on mine. He says he's sending it out the door the same as ever, and it's going, and it's just not going to me." Reed drank his pint. "He says, and I quote, it's going up the hill."

"What hill?"

"He doesn't know. He says that's just where it goes. Up the hill."

The telly above them went from the football to a bit of news, and there was the Prime Minister, Andrew Hale, standing beside the canal in the sunshine in front of the new building, saying something about the canal.

It was a good speech. You could tell without the sound. He had the look of a man who had been told about the canal by somebody who loved it and had loved it himself ever since. He looked solid and fair and a bit older than last time, the way you'd want a Prime Minister to look after the national football had gone badly, and he had a kindly sort of frown, and when he looked down at the water it was with an expression of the most patient disappointment, as though the water had gone down in the box with nobody near it and was lying there gazing up at him.

"Here," said Reed. "He looks like that referee."

Charleston looked up. "Which referee?"

"The one off the telly. You know. The one who looks at you when you're lying there."

Charleston looked at the screen for a while.

"He doesn't look like a referee to me," he said. "He looks like that bloke off the adverts. The fridge one. The bloke."

"He looks like my Uncle Clive," said Benjamin.

"He doesn't look like your Uncle Clive."

"He's the spit of our Clive. Clive had that nose. He's got Clive's nose."

"He's got a referee's nose," said Reed. "You're thinking of the referee."

"I'm not thinking of any referee. I'm thinking of our Clive. Who was a lovely man, God rest him, and would have made a very good Prime Minister, and so does this one."

They watched him finish the speech. He finished it beautifully. He put a hand on the railing of the bridge as he finished, and looked down at the canal one more time, and nodded, the way you would nod at a friend across a room.

"I like him," said Charleston.

"Everybody likes him."

"I know. That's what I like about him." Charleston thought. "Did you vote for him?"

"Nobody votes," said Benjamin.

"It came up, though. Didn't it. On your phone. That morning."

"Oh, aye," said Reed, remembering. "It came up. Had his face on. Asked if I was happy with him."

"And were you?"

"Well, yeah," said Reed. "He looked like the referee."

Nobody had anything to add to this. The news finished, and the football came back, and that was the Prime Minister dealt with.

—

On the Friday morning it was drizzling, and the car took the ridge road, and halfway along past the reservoir it slowed down without being asked.

Reed looked up from his bacon roll.

There was a Mag on the verge. It was one of the grey ones, the plain sort with no face, about the shape of a person if you didn't look too hard, and it was standing perfectly still in the wet grass with two carrier bags in its hands and its head on one side, as though it had been asked a question it couldn't answer. Beside it, under a small umbrella that was doing very little, stood the posh woman from the Rise. The one with the pale coat and her hair pinned up. She was saying something to the Mag, quite patiently, and the Mag was not doing anything about it.

The car stopped.

Reed had not told it to. But he would have, if he'd thought of it, and the car had known that before he did. It knew he was the sort of man who stopped.

He wound the window down.

"All right?"

The woman turned round. Up close she was younger than he'd thought, and prettier, and she had rain on her eyelashes, and she looked at him and at the car and at the bacon roll in a way that made him want to sit up straighter, though he could not have said why.

"Oh," she said. "Hello. Yes. Thank you. I'm fine. It's just —" She looked at the Mag. "It's stopped."

"What's up with him?"

"I think it's the wet," she said. "It doesn't like it. It's very old. It just needs a sit down, really, and someone to look at it."

"Don't we all," said Reed.

She laughed. It was a nice laugh, a surprised one, as though she hadn't been expecting to laugh at all that morning.

"Where you going?"

"Into town. Bridge Street. I'm — I walk. Normally. I was going to walk."

"In this?"

"I like walking."

"Nobody likes walking," said Reed, with conviction. "Get in. Both of you. Come on. He can go in the back."

She hesitated for about a second and a half, and then she said, "That's very kind," and did something to the Mag that made it shuffle forward, and the car opened its back door, and the Mag folded itself into the back seat with the carrier bags on its knees, like an aunt being taken to a christening, and she got in the front beside him and shook her umbrella out of the window.

The car pulled away. The radio, which had been playing something from the summer he turned twenty-two, went quietly down to nothing, as though it had been asked to mind its manners.

"Cassie," she said. "Cassie May."

"Reed. Winston Reed. Mr. Reed, mostly."

"Mr. Reed," she said, and smiled, and he got the impression she was filing it somewhere.

She was very posh. He could tell straight off. It wasn't the voice, exactly — she sounded like Brackton, same as him, not a thing put on — it was something else. The way she sat. The way she held her umbrella, as though umbrellas were a thing she had been introduced to properly at a young age. The coat. The Mag in the back seat, which was plain and grey and had no face, and which she talked to the way you'd talk to an old

dog. He knew where she lived. Everybody knew where people lived who walked down off the Rise in the mornings.

"You're a Steward," he said.

"I am."

"I've seen you. Walking. Few weeks back."

"I've seen you," said Cassie. "Eating a bacon roll."

He looked down at the bacon roll.

"Grace does them," he said. "My — she does them. Leaves them in the door."

"That's lovely."

"It is lovely. It's always bacon. Never sausage. I don't know how she knows."

Cassie looked out of the window at the reservoir going by in the drizzle and did not say anything, in a way that seemed to him, for some reason, very polite.

—

They went down off the ridge. He found he was talking. He did that, with people, and she was easy to talk to, the way a good barmaid is easy to talk to, because she listened with her whole face and laughed at the right bits and did not seem to want anything back. He told her about the football. He told her about the goalkeeper who fell over twice, and the striker who went down with nobody near him and lay there with his face, and the whole Crown going home sour, and how he'd learned his lesson on that one.

"That was you?" said Cassie. "The deckchair one?"

"You saw it?"

"Everybody saw it."

"Best thing on the telly all week," said Reed. "In my professional opinion. Don't tell anyone."

"I won't," she said, and he believed her.

She asked him what it was like, doing the football all day. Nobody had ever asked him that before. Not like she asked it, as if she actually wanted to know. He told her it was the best job in the world. He told her that before, in the old days, he'd had a job and been good at it and frightened every morning that it was going, and that now he sat in the back room with the garden through the window and picked between two corners, and it went into the football somewhere, the way a brick goes into a wall, and he never had to be frightened of anything again.

"Do you know how it works?" she said. "Where it goes?"

"No," said Reed, happily.

"Would you like to?"

She said it quite lightly. But there was something underneath it, a sort of held breath, as though she had been carrying the question about with her for a long time and had never found anybody to put it to.

"God, no," said Reed.

She turned and looked at him.

"No, honestly. I don't. You start telling me, it'll be like when you're a kid and you see the back of the telly. All them wires. You never look at it the same. I like it how it is." He finished the bacon roll. "I pick it. It goes in. Somebody falls over. That's plenty."

Cassie looked at him for a long moment. Then she laughed — not the surprised laugh, a different one, quieter, the laugh of someone who has put down something heavy.

"You're quite right," she said. "You're absolutely right. I won't tell you a thing."

"Good."

"It's nice," she said, to the window. "Meeting someone who doesn't want to know."

"Most people don't want to know."

"Most people don't know there's anything to know."

Reed thought about this.

"Well, I do," he said. "And I still don't."

They came down past the reservoir. In the back seat the grey Mag had lifted its head a little and seemed to be taking an interest. Reed glanced at it in the mirror and got the odd feeling, for a moment, that it was looking at him. It didn't have a face. You couldn't tell.

Then he had his idea.

It was not much of an idea. It was the sort of idea you have in a car in the drizzle when you have just been given a lift by luck and a Steward is sitting next to you with rain on her eyelashes. But it came up in him the way the goalkeeper had come up in him, the laugh, the picking it on the spot.

"Here," said Reed. "You couldn't do us a favour, could you?"

"Of course."

"I don't want to know how it works. I want to be clear on that. I don't want the wires."

"No wires," Cassie agreed.

"It's only — can you get me my beef?"

She blinked.

"Your beef?"

So he told her. The rib. The wedding. Garside. The Monday and Tuesday and the extra Cats, and back it came, the way it always came back. And then the dive, and the chicken with lemon in it, and the next day picking for the room, and back it came again. And then this last week. Captain Football every

night. Four extras. Enough meat credits to open a farm. And no rib. Not grey. Not anything. Just gone.

"And it's Calder tomorrow," said Reed. "You know what that means."

"I'm not sure I —"

"It means the rib. Calder Saturday, you have the rib. On a board. In the Crown. All the lads. It's how it's done. You can't do Calder on chicken." He spread his hands. "I'm not upset. I want to be clear on that and all. I'm not upset. It's only that — it's Calder."

Cassie looked at him. She did not laugh. He liked her for that. She looked at him with complete seriousness, the way you would look at a man telling you about a funeral.

"You can't do Calder on chicken," she said.

"You cannot."

"All right," said Cassie May. "Let me have a look."

—

She got her phone out. He looked away, politely, at the reservoir, because whatever she was going to do on it was wires and he had said he didn't want them, and he was a man of his word.

Out of the corner of his eye he saw her face go through some things. Interest. Then a little frown. Then a different frown, a narrower one, the sort of frown a woman gives a knitting pattern. Then she went very still.

"Well?" said Reed, after a while. "Can it?"

"Yes," said Cassie slowly. "Yes, it can. But —"

She stopped.

"But what?"

She didn't answer. She was looking at the phone. And then something happened that Reed would think about, on and off, for quite a long time afterwards, and never once understand, and never once mind not understanding.

She laughed.

Not the surprised laugh. Not the quiet one. She laughed out loud, all at once, the way he had laughed at the goalkeeper — a great helpless burst of it, right there in the front seat of his car in the middle of the ridge road, with the drizzle on the windscreen and the reservoir going by. She put her hand over her mouth and it came out round the sides. She bent over. She laughed until she had tears on top of the rain on her eyelashes, and in the back seat the grey Mag turned its smooth blank head towards her with what Reed could only have described as concern.

"Sorry," she said. "Sorry. Oh, God. Sorry."

"What?"

"It's — nothing. It's nothing to do with you. It's not your fault. You haven't done anything wrong. You've done everything right." She wiped her eyes. "You've picked beautifully, Mr. Reed. You've picked like the Pope."

"That's what I said."

"It's just — it's going up the hill."

Reed sat up.

"That's what Garside said. Up the hill. What hill?"

She looked at him with her eyes still wet, and her face doing something complicated, and he could see her trying to work out how much she could tell him without wires.

"There's some very big lads," said Cassie carefully, "up the hill. Who work very hard. And somebody who's very fond of

them decided they should have the best there is. And the best there is —"

"Is Garside's rib."

"Is Garside's rib."

"All of it?"

"All of it."

Reed thought about this.

He thought about it honestly, the way he'd once thought about whether a goalkeeper ought to fall to his left or to his right. He thought about very big lads, up a hill, who worked very hard. He thought, for some reason, about two Brutes going past the window of the Crown, and one of them with a steel box on his shoulder the size of a chest freezer, and a lad in a good jacket stepping up to him. He didn't know why he thought about that. It went past, like a car, and was gone.

"Well," he said. "Fair enough."

Cassie stared at him.

"Fair enough?"

"If they're big lads," said Reed reasonably. "And they work hard. And somebody's fond of them. They want feeding, don't they? Big lads." He looked out of the window at the rain. "Bit much, all of it. Could've left one for Calder. But fair enough."

There was a long silence in the car. The radio, very quietly, had come back on, and was playing something he half knew, from the back of a minibus coming home from the coast.

"Mr. Reed," said Cassie May at last, in a voice he hadn't heard her use, "you are the nicest man I have met in eleven years."

"Get away."

"I mean it."

"You want to get out more," said Reed kindly, and the car pulled up on Bridge Street outside the Assay.

She got out. The grey Mag got out after her, with the carrier bags, and stood on the pavement under the clock looking a good deal better for the sit down. Cassie put up her small useless umbrella. Then she bent down to the window, the way somebody had bent down to her window once, and looked at him through the glass.

"Go to Garside's," she said. "Tomorrow. First thing. Seven o'clock, when he opens."

"What for?"

"I can't promise. I mean it. I can't promise you anything. But go at seven."

He looked at her. She had stopped laughing. She looked, if anything, slightly frightened, though it was gone before he'd properly seen it, the way the Brutes went past.

"Right you are," said Reed. "Seven."

She went in under the clock.

He sat in the car for a minute in the drizzle, thinking that she was very posh, and very nice, and that it was a shame about her Mag, which was the plainest thing he had ever seen, and that it took all sorts. Then he told the car the Exchange, and it went, and the radio found the next song before he'd thought of it, and he did not think about the hill again all day.

—

Cassie went up the stairs of the Assay two at a time, past Ellis with his mug, and sat down at her desk, and did not look at Brackton.

She looked at the meat board instead. The thin grey line along the bottom. Rib of beef, aged, Garside's. She had noticed

it a fortnight ago, frowned at it, and forgotten it. It had got thinner since. Since last Thursday it had not been a thin place at all; it had been a hole. Every single cut that came out of Garside's back door went the same way, up the hill, in a black car with no radio, to the gate and the gatehouse and the old bus depot by the gasworks, on the strength of a single line in the Clerk's figures that she could see from here, signed off in the flat grey voice, on Sterling's say-so. All of it. To the Lines. Every day.

And underneath, in the Clerk's own hand, because the Clerk existed to disagree, one small note that it had added, and that nobody had read until now:

One man in Brackton will be mildly puzzled.

She started laughing again. She couldn't help it. Ellis put his head round the screen.

"What's up with you?"

"Mildly puzzled," said Cassie, and laughed so much she had to put her head on the desk.

Then, when she had stopped, she sat up, and wiped her face, and put her hands in her lap where they could be seen, though there was nobody there to see them, and called Ashcombe.

—

Sterling took it in the kitchen. She could hear the dog.

She told him. She told it the way she told him about the town, the way he liked: not the board, the street. The drizzle and the grey Mag stopped on the verge and the long silver car slowing down without being asked. The bacon roll. The goalkeeper. A man who did not want to see the back of the telly. Calder Saturday, and the rib on a board, and how you can't do

Calder on chicken. Up the hill. And then the thing he had said, looking out at the rain.

"He said fair enough?" said Sterling.

"He said they're big lads and they want feeding."

There was a long quiet on the line. She heard the dog's claws on the stone floor. She heard, very faintly, the Clerk saying something in the background, and Sterling saying, "Yes, all right, I know, I know you did."

"What's his name?"

"Reed. Winston Reed. They call him Captain Football. In the Crown."

"In the Crown," said Sterling Bronson, very softly, as though she had said, in heaven.

And then he said the thing she had been afraid, all the way up the stairs, that he was going to say.

"I want to meet him."

"You can't."

"I'd like to give it to him myself. The rib. I'd like to hand it over. I'd like to shake his hand and say, sorry about that, Captain, that was me, I didn't think. And I'd like to meet Garside. I've wanted to meet Garside for nine years."

"You can't," said Cassie again. "You know you can't. You know better than anybody. The Clerk will have told you."

"The Clerk is telling me now."

"Then listen to it."

"I always listen to it. I just don't always do what it says. That's rather the point of it." She heard him get up. She heard the scrape of the chair on the stone. "When does Garside open?"

She shut her eyes.

"Seven," said Cassie.

“Seven on a Saturday. In the drizzle. Nobody’s about at seven on a Saturday in the drizzle. Clerk — who’s about at seven on a Saturday?”

She heard the Clerk, faintly, answer him. She heard a number. It was not a small number.

“Well, I’ll wear a hat,” said Sterling.

“A hat,” said Cassie.

“And a scarf. And I’ll take the lads from the gate. Walsh and the others. They’ll be with me. Nothing can happen with them there. And you’ll come. You’ll have to come. You found him. You’ll have to introduce us.” He was quiet for a moment. “I want to do one thing myself, Cassie. Just one. I’ve been looking at that town through a telescope for ten years. I want to go down and say sorry to one man about his tea.”

She sat at her desk in the long room above the canal, with Brackton leaning gently over the board in front of her in all its colours, and her hands in her lap, and thought about the gate, and the four of them standing at it, and a man with a scar through one eyebrow stopping with his hand on the iron.

Nothing can happen with them there.

“All right,” she said. “Seven.”

“Seven,” said Sterling, delighted, and rang off.

At the next desk Ellis had stopped pretending not to listen. He put the mug down. He looked at her for a long time over the top of it, and for once there was nothing at all of the joke in his face.

“Keep your hands where they can see them,” he said. “All of you. Tomorrow. Every one of you.”

“I always do.”

“I know,” said Ellis. “I know you do. I meant him.”

CHAPTER EIGHT

Reed got to the covered market at ten to seven, which was the earliest he had been anywhere on a Saturday since about 2029.

He had told Grace the night before that he had to be at Garside's first thing, and she had said, "Have you?" in a way that was very nearly her normal way, and then, "Why?" and he had said a Steward had told him to, and Grace had gone quiet again, the new quiet, the cupboard quiet, and then put her head on his shoulder and said, "Well. Wrap up warm," and that was all. There had been a bacon roll in the door pocket this morning, same as ever. But it had been wrapped in two napkins instead of one, which had never happened before, and he had sat in the car looking at the second napkin for some time without being able to say what it meant.

It was still drizzling. The market was only half awake. The cheese men were taking the cloths off their counters and had not yet started arguing, which gave the whole hall the slightly unnatural hush of a church before a christening. A woman was hosing down the fish. Three old men had come in for

their tea at the café by the door, as they did every morning, and were saying good morning to each other very slowly.

At the back, Garside was putting his shutter up.

"Mr. Reed," he said. "You're keen."

"I was told seven."

"Who by?"

"A Steward."

Garside stopped with the shutter halfway. He was broad and pink and had opinions about everything, and Reed watched him try to find one about this, and fail, which he had never seen happen.

"Well," said Garside eventually. "I've nowt for you. If it's the rib. It's all gone up the hill. Same as all week."

"I know. She said it might not come."

"Then what are you here for?"

Reed considered this. "She said seven."

Garside looked at him a while longer and then shrugged and got the shutter the rest of the way up, and went into the back. Reed heard him in there, banging about, talking to himself. When he came out again he had a parcel in brown paper, tied with string, and he set it down on the counter on Reed's side, not looking at it, the way you set down something you are not supposed to have.

"What's that?"

"That," said Garside, "is the last one. The very last rib in Brackton. The car comes for them at eight. I counted them out last night for the car and there was one over, and I don't know how, because there's never one over, and I put it on one side, and I said to myself, Garside, you're keeping that for nobody, and then I thought, no, I'm keeping it for Calder." He put both hands flat on the counter. "I can't give it you. It's not

on your screen. It's spoken for. But I wanted you to see it. So you know it exists."

Reed looked at the parcel. It was the right size. It was the right weight; he could tell from here. You could just see, at one end where the paper didn't quite meet, the dark edge of it, and the white of the fat.

"That's good of you," he said, and meant it.

"It's not good of me. It's torture. I don't know why I've done it." Garside wiped his hands on his apron. "I think I've gone soft."

Outside, a long black car pulled up at the Bridge Street end of the market, and the radio in it, if it had had one, would have been off.

—

Cassie got out first.

She had not slept at all. Not the old way, not any way. She had lain on her back on Hollin Rise with the ceiling a long way off and Tuesday standing in the doorway with the tissues, and at four she had got up and had a bath, and at five Ellis had knocked on her door with two mugs, without being asked, and they had sat in her kitchen in silence and drunk them, and when the car came he had walked her to the end of the drive and said, "Hands," and squeezed her shoulder, and gone back up the lawn without looking round.

Now she stood on the wet cobbles at the end of Bridge Street with her hands out of her pockets and watched the others get out.

The Brutes first. Four from the gate, and a fifth that the Clerk had sent in the night without being asked, from the canal frame, because it was nearby and because it knew him:

a grey-stubbled man with a crease between his eyebrows who stood very still at the back of the car and looked at nothing. They unfolded out of the car the way they always did, one by one, each of them taking far too long to finish standing up, until there was a wall of black kit on the pavement with white letters down the arms, and the drizzle running off the shoulder plates.

Walsh was the last of the four. He looked at her once. Then his eyes went down to the cobbles.

Then Sterling got out.

He had on a flat cap, and a scarf wound twice round the bottom of his face, and a long waxed coat with the collar up, and a pair of glasses that Cassie had never seen before and suspected he did not need. He looked exactly like what he was, which was the most famous man in the country wearing a hat.

"Well?" he said, through the scarf. "How do I look?"

"Like you," said Cassie. "In a hat."

"Nonsense. Nobody'll look twice."

Across the street a woman with a pram stopped dead.

—

It took about a minute and a half.

That was what Cassie would remember, afterwards, more than anything: how quick it was. She had seen the Clerk's curve. She had seen it the night before, on her own screen, when she couldn't sleep, the long smooth line of it going up and up from the moment he stepped out of the car. She had known, as a number, exactly how fast it would go. It went faster.

The woman with the pram took out her phone. She did not take a picture; she was too polite for that, and too stunned. She just held it, and said something into it, very quietly, the way you'd ring your sister to say you'd seen a fox in the garden. And somewhere in Brackton her sister's phone lit up, and her sister's face did something, and her sister said it to somebody else.

They went into the market. Sterling went first, with the cap pulled down, and the Brutes round him in a loose ring, two in front and two behind and the grey-stubbled one at the back, and Cassie at his elbow, and the dog was not there, which she found she minded very much. He walked like a man going into a church he had not been to since he was a boy. He looked at everything. He looked at the cheese. He looked at the fish. He looked at the three old men in the café by the door, and the three old men looked at him, and very slowly put their tea down.

"Good morning," said Sterling to them, through the scarf.

"Good — morning," said the first old man, at about a third of his normal speed.

The cheese men had stopped taking the cloths off. One of them still had a cloth in his hands. The woman with the hose had let it go, and it was going round and round on the floor of the fish stall like a thing alive, and nobody was turning it off.

And at the back of the hall, at the butcher's counter, a broad pink man in an apron, who had opinions about everything, looked up from wiping down and saw who was walking towards him between the stalls, and put his cloth down, and did not pick it up again.

—

Reed had his back to all of it.

He was looking at the parcel. He was trying to work out whether it would be bad manners to ask Garside if he could just hold it for a minute, not to take it, just to feel the weight of it, the way you might ask to hold somebody's baby. He had decided it probably would be, and was going to ask anyway, when he noticed that Garside had stopped talking.

Garside never stopped talking. Reed looked up.

Garside was staring over his shoulder with his mouth open.

"What?" said Reed, and turned round.

There was a man standing behind him in a flat cap and a scarf and a pair of glasses, with a ring of Brutes round him, and the posh woman from the car. The man took the scarf down. Then he took the glasses off. Then, because there seemed no point in it any longer, he took the cap off too, and stood there in the drizzly half-light of the covered market with the face.

Reed knew it before the cap was off. Everybody would have. You could no more not know it than not know your own street. He had seen it every night for a year and a half, when he was frightened, saying it was going to be all right, and he had believed it, and it had been.

"Here," said Reed. "You're him."

"I am," said Sterling Bronson. "Sorry about that." He held out his hand. "Mr. Reed? Captain Football?"

Reed shook it. It was a dry hand, not soft. It held on a bit longer than you would.

"Who told you that?"

"She did." Sterling nodded at Cassie. "She tells me everything. She tells me about the town. You're very famous

up our way, you know. The deckchair. The goalkeeper who fell over twice."

"That was mine," said Reed, unable to help it.

"I know. I laughed for a week."

This was, Reed would say later, in the Crown, the single best thing anybody had ever said to him, and he had been told he was in great nick by a transistor.

Then Sterling turned to the counter, and looked at Garside, and his face changed again, into something Cassie had seen on it only once before, when she told him about her mother's Mag with her father's laugh.

"Mr. Garside," he said.

Garside said nothing. For the first and only time in his life, Garside had no opinion about anything at all.

"I've eaten your beef every Sunday for nine years," said Sterling. "And Thursdays. And the odd Tuesday. I've wanted to come down and shake your hand the whole time. I've met the Prime Minister. You're better."

"The Prime Minister's a referee," said Reed helpfully.

"Exactly my point," said Sterling, and put his hand out across the counter.

Garside looked at the hand. Then he wiped his own, very slowly, on his apron, front and back, and took it.

"It's the hanging," he said. His voice came out strange and small. "What I do to it. Everybody asks. It's just the hanging. Thirty-five days. In the cold. And you turn it. Every morning, you turn it, by hand. A Mag couldn't do it. A Mag doesn't know when."

"How do you know when?"

Garside thought about it. "You just know," he said. "You've got to care, I suppose."

Sterling Bronson stood at the butcher's counter with the whole country's face and looked at Garside for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "Yes. That's it, isn't it. That's the whole of it."

Then he looked down at the counter, at the parcel in brown paper tied with string, sitting on Reed's side.

"Is that the last one?"

"It is," said Garside. "It's yours. It's spoken for. The car comes at eight."

"It's not mine," said Sterling. "It never was. I just didn't think." He picked it up, felt the weight of it in both hands the way Reed had wanted to, and turned round and held it out. "Mr. Reed. I've been taking your beef. Well — my lads have. I told them they should have the best there was and I didn't stop to think what that meant, and it meant yours. I'm sorry. Here."

Reed looked at the parcel. He looked at the man. He looked, for some reason, past the man at the ring of Brutes, standing very still in the drizzly light with their eyes on the floor, huge, tired, with their white letters down their arms.

"They can have it," said Reed. "If they want. Big lads."

"They've had it all week," said Sterling gently. "They'll have it again tonight. Garside'll hang some more. Take it. It's Calder."

Reed took it.

It was the right weight. It was exactly the right weight.

"Cheers," he said. "That's good of you."

"It's the least —" Sterling began, and stopped, and smiled. "It's nothing. Enjoy your match."

And that would have been all of it, Cassie thought afterwards. That would have been all of it, if it had taken him three

minutes and not four.

—

The market had filled up behind them.

She hadn't heard it happen. She had been watching the parcel. But when she turned round, the hall behind the ring of Brutes was full of people, and the doors at the Bridge Street end were full of people, and more people were coming in past them, in coats and dressing gowns and pyjama bottoms with coats over, in the drizzle, at four minutes past seven on a Saturday morning. Two hundred. Three. She stopped being able to count. They had come from the cafés and the houses and the cars, from the barber's on Mill Street, where the barber had come out with a comb still in his hand and his customer behind him with half a head of hair. They had come because their phones had told them, and their sisters had told them, and because there was not one person in Brackton who would not have got out of bed in the rain to see that face.

They were not angry. That was the thing. Not one of them. Cassie looked along the front of the crowd and saw nothing but delight. They were smiling. They were holding their phones up. They were calling out to him, "Morning!" and "Thank you!" and "Is it true about the dog?" and a woman near the front was crying and saying, "You said it'd be all right, you said it'd be all right, and it was," over and over, as though she had been waiting ten years to say it and was afraid it would go back in if she stopped.

And they were pressing.

Not pushing. Nobody was pushing. It was only that there were so many of them, and the ones at the back wanted to see, and leaned, and the ones in front of them leaned too, and

the whole warm delighted mass of the crowd moved forward towards the butcher's counter a step at a time, the way the tide comes in over flat sand, so gently you only notice when your shoes are wet.

The Brutes did not move. The ring held. The crowd came up against the black kit and stopped, and leaned, and the front row of them were pressed against the plated chests of men three times their size, and the men did not step back, and did not step forward, and stood with their hands at their sides and their eyes on the floor and the drizzle-light on their shoulders, and let themselves be leaned on.

Cassie looked at the Brutes' hands. All five pairs of them were at their sides. All of them were open.

She looked at Sterling. He was looking at the crowd with an expression she would never be able to describe to anybody, and never tried. He looked like a man who has been told that the thing he has spent his life building is a cathedral, and has walked in, and found it full.

And then, at the back, by the cheese, somebody started laughing in a different way.

—

The lad in the good jacket had been out all night.

You could see it on him. Him and his two mates. They came in from the Kenning Street end, where the Feathers was, with their faces grey and their eyes too bright, and they shoved — really shoved, the first shoving there had been — through the back of the crowd, laughing, saying "'Scuse me, 'scuse me, VIP," and people let them through, because people were in a good mood, and because the lad in the good jacket

had a way of moving through a crowd that made people let him.

He came out at the front, beside the ring, at the end where Walsh was standing.

He looked at Sterling. He grinned. He held up his phone and took a picture of Sterling, with the flash, right in his face, and Sterling blinked and smiled politely.

Then he turned and looked up at the Brute beside him.

And Cassie saw him know him.

She saw it go across his face — the grey, out-all-night face — like a light coming on in a back room. He looked at the scar through the eyebrow. He looked at the chest plate. WALSH. His grin went wider, and something else came into it, something that had been frightened on a pavement on Kenning Street with wet trousers, and had laughed about it all the way up the street, and had been laughing about it ever since, because the alternative was to stop.

"It's you," said the lad. "It's the neck one."

Walsh did not move.

"It is! Lads — it's him. It's the one off the video. The one who done his mate." He was delighted. He was swaying a bit. "Go on, then. Go on. Do me. Like you done him."

"Sorry, sir," said Walsh, to the floor.

"Sorry, sir," said the lad, in a voice. His mates laughed. "Sorry, sir. Sorry, sir. You weren't sorry on Kenning Street, were you? You weren't sorry when you snapped him like a —" and he made a sound with his tongue, a little wet click, and his mates nearly fell over.

The crowd had not noticed. That was what Cassie would remember. The crowd was still pressing forward, warm and loud and delighted, calling out to Sterling, holding up its

phones. Nobody was looking at the end of the ring. Only her. And Sterling, who had turned his head.

And the grey-stubbled Brute at the back, the one the Clerk had sent from the canal, who had stopped looking at nothing and was looking at Walsh, and whose hand had come up to his ear.

The lad reached up — a long way up — and tapped on Walsh's headset with one finger. Tap tap.

"Anybody home?"

Then he hooked his finger under it, and flicked it off.

It went over Walsh's shoulder and hit the cobbles and skidded, a little grey plastic thing, under the edge of Garside's counter, and lay there.

And the crowd leaned in, all at once, the whole warm mass of it, because the old woman at the back with the trolley had finally got her phone out and somebody had stepped back on to her foot and she had cried out, and everybody in front of her had shuffled forward to give her room. And the front of the crowd came forward against the ring. And Sterling, who had turned his head, stumbled half a step, and a man in a dressing gown caught him by the arm and said, "Whoa, there, sir, whoa," and held on to him, delighted, not letting go.

And the lad in the good jacket, laughing, put both hands flat on Walsh's chest plate, and shoved.

—

I'll tell you this bit myself. I want to. It's the only bit of any of it that's mine.

The ear's gone.

That's the first thing. It's gone. It's on the floor under the counter and I can see it, out of the side of my eye, a little grey

thing, and there's nothing in my head. Nothing. Eleven years and there's never once been nothing. There's been the click and the voice like the shipping forecast all day and the Sergeant all night and the jabs, and now there's this. It's like walking out of a factory into a field. I can hear the market. I can hear the hose going round on the floor of the fish stall. I can hear a woman crying at the front saying you said it'd be all right. I can hear the rain on the roof.

And I can hear him.

He's got his hands on my chest. The lad. The same lad. He's pushing. It's like being pushed by a cat. I can feel his heart going through my plate, that's how hard he's pushing, and it doesn't move me at all, not an inch, and he knows it, and he's laughing.

And behind him there's six hundred people and they're all leaning, and the Owner's gone half over and there's a man in a dressing gown with hold of his arm, and I'm the nearest.

I'm the nearest. And there's no ear. And the Sergeant says a Brute in a crowd that's pressing on an Owner has an order for that, and the order is clear the space, and I know how to clear a space. I know exactly how. I did six years in the army and eleven at the barn and I know how you clear a space, and the first bit of it is the lad in front of you.

My hand's on him.

I didn't decide. It's just there. It's on the front of his good jacket and his throat's under my thumb and I can feel it moving when he laughs. It's so small. It's like a bird. I could close my hand. It'd take less than turning a gate. And there's no ear to say Walsh, and nobody'd know it was me that decided and not the order, and I'd be clearing the space, and he poured a pint over Kenny's head and said, now you've had a drink in the Crown.

I'm telling you this so you know. I want to close my hand. I want to more than I've wanted anything since Donna. I want him to look at me, eye to eye, for two seconds, and see.

And Gaz is behind me.

I don't look. I don't need to. I can feel him. He's stood exactly where I stood on Kenning Street, and his arm's come up, and his hand's nearly on the back of my head, the way they taught us, and he's got his ear. His ear's still on. And I know what's in it. And I know that if my hand closes his arm turns, and it'll be quick, because it's Gaz, and he'll be sorry, and they'll send somebody we know to carry me.

And our Liam'll get my beef.

That's what does it. Not Gaz. Not the ear. That. That's what I hear, in the nothing where the ear should be. Not a voice like the shipping forecast. My own. Saying it in my own head, in my own words, the way you say your own name:

I'm slow, and that's all right.

I'm strong, and that's what I'm for.

They're fragile, and it's not their fault.

And that's when I know. Standing there with my hand on him and no ear. That I never needed it. That it's not in the ear any more and it hasn't been for years. It's in me. It's me. They don't need the ear. They could take every headset off every Brute in the Lines tomorrow and throw them in the canal and nothing would change, not a thing, not one of us, because it's not in there. It's down where Donna used to be.

I open my hand.

The lad drops back on to his heels. He's stopped laughing. He looks up at me and for one second, one, he's looking at me eye to eye, and I let him. I let him see. I don't know what he sees. Something. His face goes white.

Then I put my eyes down on the cobbles.

"Sorry, sir," I say.

And I bend down — it takes a long time, bending down, at my size — and I reach under Garside's counter, and I get the ear, and I put it back on, and it clicks, and the voice comes back, warm, like a hand on the back of the neck, and says, Good.

And Gaz's arm goes down.

—

Reed was talking to Garside about Calder.

He had turned back to the counter the moment the beef was in his hands, because that was where you put a thing that heavy, and he had been telling Garside about Benjamin crying at the header in 2034 and denying it ever since, and Garside, who had got a bit of himself back by now, had been saying that he had been at that game and had cried himself and wasn't ashamed to say so. Behind him, the market roared. Reed took no notice of it. Markets roared. There'd been a bit of shoving at one point — he'd felt somebody knock against his back — and then it had stopped.

"What was all that?" he said, turning round with the parcel under his arm.

There was nothing to see. The Brutes were standing in their ring, exactly as before, eyes down, hands at their sides. The one at the end, with the scar through his eyebrow, was settling his headset on his ear. A young lad in a good jacket was backing away into the crowd with two mates, looking very white, the way lads look at seven in the morning when they've been out all night and it's caught up with them. The Owner was being helped upright by a man in a dressing gown, and laughing, and saying, "Thank you, I'm quite all right, thank

you," and the posh woman was standing very still with her hands out of her pockets and her face gone the colour of the market's whitewash.

"Nothing, lad," said Garside, who had seen none of it either. "Just folk."

"Big crowd."

"Well. It's him, isn't it."

"Fair enough," said Reed, and hitched the parcel up under his arm, and looked at it with love.

—

Sterling got up on to a crate.

Nobody had told him to. Cassie watched him do it with her heart somewhere near her mouth. He found an empty crate by Garside's counter that had come in with the chickens, and turned it over, and stood on it, so that he was a head above the crowd and three heads below the Brutes, and he took off his scarf and held up both hands, and the whole of the covered market went quiet.

It went quiet because it was his face, and they had stopped for that face once every night for a year and a half, and it turned out they still knew how.

"Morning, everybody," said Sterling Bronson.

"Morning," said six hundred people, more or less together, at about a third of their normal speed.

"It's lovely to see you. It really is. You've no idea." He looked at them. He looked at them for so long that a few of them started to shuffle. "I came down for some beef. That's all. I've got it now. Well, I've given it away, actually, but that's my business." A laugh went round. "And now I'm going home. And so are you. It's Saturday and it's raining and half of you have got

your pyjamas on under your coats — I can see you, Mrs. — and it's Calder this afternoon. Go home. Have your breakfast. Go to the match." He paused. "And — thank you. All of you. For all of it. Every single thing you pick. You don't know what you do. You don't need to. But it's everything. It's all of it. It's you."

There was a silence.

Then the woman who had been crying at the front said, "Is it true about the dog?"

"It's a Labrador," said Sterling. "It's very good with children."

And the market cheered him. Properly. The way the Crown cheered a header in the eighty-ninth minute. And then, because he had asked them to, and because he was the face, and because they were Brackton and Brackton had always done what it was asked when it was asked nicely, they began, slowly, laughing and talking and holding up their phones for one last picture, to go home.

The Brutes took him out through the side door by the fish. Cassie went with them. Reed stood at the counter with his parcel and watched them go, and as they went past him the Owner caught his eye and gave him a nod, the nod you'd give a mate across a room, and Reed gave it back.

The last Brute through the door was the one with the scar. He did not look at anybody. His hand was at his ear.

—

In the back of the black car, on the way up the moor road, Sterling sat with his cap in his lap and did not say anything for a long time.

Cassie sat beside him. She had stopped shaking somewhere around the reservoir. In the seat opposite them, folded

into the car with his knees nearly up to his chest, because he was the one Sterling had asked to ride inside, sat Walsh, looking at the floor.

The drizzle had stopped. The moor came up on either side, green and brown and empty. Over the top of the hill the coil slid by in its valley, under its shimmer.

"Walsh," said Sterling.

"Sir."

"I saw."

The Brute said nothing. His hand was at his ear. Sterling leaned across the car and, very gently, as you might move a child's hand from a hot pan, took the hand away from the ear and put it back down on the Brute's knee, and left his own hand on top of it. It covered about a quarter of it.

"I saw what you did," said Sterling. "I saw what you didn't do. I want to say something to you. I've wanted to say it since Kenning Street, and I couldn't, at the wall. I want to say it now. You don't have to say anything. You don't have to look at me. Just let me say it."

Walsh looked at the floor.

"We never really wanted to hurt you," said Sterling Bronson. "Any of you. I need you to know that, even if it doesn't help. It's true. We do love you. I know how that sounds. I know what we've done. But we do." He was quiet for a moment. "You're so bloody strong. That's all it ever was. You're so bloody strong you could have outpowered us any day you liked. Any one of those mornings. You still could. You could have taken all of it. And you didn't. You take the greatest weight of this whole world, every day, in your stride, and you never once put it down."

The car went over a cattle grid. Nobody moved.

"We couldn't have given it to a Cat bloke," said Sterling. "We looked. We did look. They'd have gone bloody mad. In a week. You saw what happened to the actors. That poor sod Vale on his bench. They couldn't even bear to be told they weren't needed for the jumping off things. Imagine giving them this." He shook his head. "You do your job, and you do it well, under the worst circumstances anybody's ever been asked to bear. I sit up there and look at the figures. That's my end. You stand at the gate. We're not the best of us, Walsh. We never were. You are. That's why we gave it all to you."

He looked out of the window at the coil going by.

"And we're scared of you," he said. "That's the truth. We're scared of you because you could take it all over. All of it. In an afternoon. And we couldn't stop you. That's why we did it. Not because you're less. Because you're more." He turned back. "And today, in that market. With the ear off. With that lad's hands on you and six hundred people leaning and me going over. I watched you. And even through all of it — everything we've put in you, every jab, every night of that bloody panel on the wall — you still hold the best view of humanity of anybody I've ever met. You opened your hand."

His voice went, then, a bit. He waited till it came back.

"You are really the best of all of us," he said. "We could never do what you do. Not one of us. That's why you bear it."

It was quiet in the car for a long time. The moor went by. Cassie had her hands in her lap, and she found that she could not see them very well.

Then the Brute spoke. He did not look up. His voice was soft and careful, the voice they all had, the voice for handling something fragile.

"Thank you, sir," said Darren Walsh.

And Cassie, sitting beside them both, could not have told you — then, or ever, though she thought about it every morning for the rest of her life on the walk down off the Rise — whether that was the panel on the wall saying it, or the man.

She didn't think he could have told you either.

The car came down into the hollow out of the wind, and the old trees, and the gate. The other three were already back at their posts. Walsh unfolded himself from the car, one piece at a time, and went and stood at the end of the gate with his hand on the iron, and the car went through, and he did not look at it.

Sterling got out at the house. The dog came out to meet him, wild with joy, as though he had been gone ten years instead of two hours, and he knelt down on the wet gravel in his long waxed coat and put his arms round it.

"Clerk," he said, into the dog's neck.

"Yes," said the Clerk, from the doorway.

"You were right."

"I was right about the crowd," said the Clerk. "I was wrong about Walsh."

Sterling looked up.

"I gave you a figure," said the Clerk, in its flat grey voice, "for what he would do with the ear off. In a crowd. With his hand on that boy. I gave you the figure last night, when you asked, and you went anyway."

"What was the figure?"

The Clerk told him.

Sterling knelt on the gravel with his arms round his dog for a long time after that, and did not get up, and the Clerk, which existed to disagree with him, waited in the doorway,

and for once in its long life found that it had nothing else to say.

CHAPTER NINE

Grace was on the sofa when he came in, with her feet tucked under her, and she looked up at him the way she always looked up, as though he were the best thing that had happened all day.

The new quiet had gone. He could see that straight off. Whatever it was that had been in the cupboard with her all week, it had gone back wherever things went, and she was Grace again, all the way through, and the little line between her eyebrows was nowhere to be seen.

He held up the parcel.

"Got my beef," he said.

"I know." She moved over to make room. "Go on, then. Tell me everything."

So he told her. He sat down beside her with the parcel on his knee, because he didn't want to put it down yet, and he told her about the market at ten to seven, and the cheese men not arguing, and Garside going into the back and coming out with the last rib in Brackton tied up in string. He told her about the man in the hat.

"Him?" said Grace.

"Him."

"The actual —"

"The actual. Off the telly. The face. He took his hat off and I said, here, you're him, and he said sorry about that."

Grace laughed in exactly the right place. "He never."

"He did. He shook my hand. He knew about the goalkeeper." Reed sat back. "He said he laughed for a week."

"Well, of course he did," said Grace. "Everybody did."

"And then he gave me this." He put both hands on the parcel. "Said it was his lads had been having it. Up the hill. Big lads. Said he didn't think. Said sorry."

"What was he like?"

Reed thought about it. He thought about the dry hand that held on a bit longer than you would, and the face, and the man getting up on a chicken crate to tell six hundred people in pyjamas to go home.

"He was all right," he said. "Bit sad round the eyes. Nice, though. You'd have a pint with him."

"Would you?"

"If he came in." He shrugged. "He won't, though. Can't even nip out for a paper. You should've seen the crowd."

Grace put her head on his shoulder.

"I'm glad you got your beef," she said.

"So am I."

"I'm glad it was you."

He didn't know what she meant by that, and didn't ask. It sounded nice. He sat with the parcel on his knee and her head on his shoulder and the bacon roll's second napkin still in his coat pocket, and it occurred to him, vaguely, the way things occurred to him, that whatever had been wrong all week was

not wrong any more, and that he would never find out what it had been, and that he didn't mind in the slightest.

—

The Crown on a Calder Saturday was full by one.

It had been a pub for two hundred years and had seen a great many Calder Saturdays, and it took them the way it took everything, by doing absolutely nothing differently, only more so. The telly in the corner was the same telly. The pints arrived without being asked for, the exact shade everybody liked. There were Rovers scarves on men who would have denied, on any other day of the year, that they owned a scarf. And in the corner under the telly, where they had been, in some sense, for years, were Charleston and Benjamin, with a space between them that was the shape of Reed.

"Here he is," said Charleston.

"Evening, lads."

"It's dinnertime."

"It's Calder," said Reed. "It's evening all day."

He put the parcel on the table.

They looked at it. Benjamin looked at it with the face of a man reviewing a doctoral thesis. Charleston reached out one finger and touched the string.

"Is that —"

"It is."

"How?"

"The last one in Brackton." Reed sat down. "The very last one. Garside's doing it for us. Him in the back's putting it on a board." He nodded at the bar, where the landlord was already holding out his hands for it with the reverence of a man being handed a christening.

“But it’s gone,” said Benjamin. “It’s been gone all week. It’s been going up the hill. You said.”

“It was.”

“So how’ve you got it?”

Reed took a long first drink of his pint, with his eyes closed. Then he opened them.

“Him off the telly gave it me,” he said. “This morning. In the market.”

There was a pause.

“Who off the telly?”

“Him. The Owner. Him with the face. Twenty-seven, twenty-eight. Never off it.”

Charleston and Benjamin looked at each other.

“How many have you had?” said Charleston.

“This is my first.”

“In here. How many have you had before you came in here?”

“I’m telling you. Garside’s at seven. He came in with a hat on and a ring of Brutes round him and he took his hat off and shook my hand, and he said, Captain Football, and he gave me the rib. And then he got on a crate.”

“A crate,” said Benjamin.

“A chicken crate. And told everybody to go home because it was raining.”

There was a longer pause. And then a man at the next table, a big man in a Rovers scarf whom Reed half knew from the Exchange, leaned over and said, “He’s right, you know. My missus was there. In her dressing gown,” and got his phone out, and there it was, on the little screen, shaky and loud and full of people: the covered market, the cheese, a ring of Brutes like a wall, and in the middle of it all a tall man with a long sad

face standing on a crate with his hands up, and the whole market going quiet.

And at the very edge of the picture, if you looked, with the last rib in Brackton under his arm, talking to Garside about something completely different and paying no attention whatsoever, the back of Winston Reed's head.

"That's me," said Reed, pointing. "That's my head."

Charleston looked at the phone for a long time. Then he looked at Reed.

"You met him," he said.

"I did."

"You met one of the Owners."

"I did."

"And you were talking to Garside."

"We were talking about Calder," said Reed. "Garside cried at the Calder header in thirty-four, and all. Same as you, Ben."

"I did not cry at the Calder header in thirty-four."

"Garside says he's not ashamed of it."

"Garside can say what he likes. I was not crying. I had a thing in my eye."

"For twenty minutes."

"It was a big thing."

And that, more or less, was the Owner dealt with. Charleston wanted to know what he was like, and Reed told him he was all right, bit sad round the eyes, you'd have a pint with him, and Charleston nodded slowly and said he'd always thought he looked like a decent sort, and Benjamin said he'd had his poster, the one where he was shaking hands with all them builders, and Charleston said everybody had that poster, and then the teams came out on the telly and nobody said anything about anything for some time.

—

The rib came out at half-time, on a board, pink in the middle and charred at the edges, and the landlord carried it across the Crown with both hands, and the whole pub turned to watch it go.

There was only the one. There was only the one in the whole of Brackton. People had come in early for it, the way they did every Calder Saturday, and found it wasn't there, and been very good about it, and had the lamb. They watched it go past the way you'd watch somebody else's wedding car.

It went down on the table in front of Reed.

He looked at it for a moment before he touched it, the way people in old paintings look at things that have come down from heaven. Then he picked up the knife.

He cut three slices. One for Charleston. One for Benjamin. One for himself. Then he looked at what was left, which was quite a lot, because Garside's ribs were not small, and he looked round the Crown at the men having the lamb.

"Go on, then," he said, to nobody in particular, and pushed the board into the middle of the table. "It's Calder."

It went round the whole corner under the telly. A slice each. Then the next table. Then the man in the Rovers scarf whose missus had been there in her dressing gown. There was a slice for the landlord, who refused it twice and then ate it standing up behind the bar with his eyes shut. By the time the board had gone round there was nothing on it but juice and a bit of charred fat, and Benjamin took that.

Over by the window, at the table where he always sat, the doctor was watching them with a glass of red wine he had not touched for some time.

Reed caught his eye. He did not know why. It was not a thing he usually did. But the doctor was looking, and Reed was in a very good mood, and the board was empty, and there was nothing to give the man except a nod.

So he nodded.

And the doctor, after a moment, nodded back.

"He nods," said Charleston, who had seen. "If you nod first."

"He's all right, him," said Reed, and forgot about him, which, to Reed, was about as interesting a thing as had ever happened to that doctor, and the doctor seemed, in his way, to take it as one.

—

Before the second half, instead of the adverts, the telly showed the Prime Minister.

Andrew Hale stood on the touchline at the Rovers ground in a Rovers scarf, in the drizzle, and said a few words about Calder, and about 1889, and about how there were some things that no amount of anything could ever quite take the feeling out of, and the whole of the Crown went quiet to listen to him, because he was very good at this, and because every man in the room liked him more than any man they had ever met.

He looked solid and fair and a bit older than last week. He had a kindly sort of frown. When he looked out at the pitch, it was with an expression of the most patient disappointment, as though the pitch had gone down in the box with nobody near it and was lying there gazing up at him.

"Referee," said Reed, with great satisfaction.

"Our Clive," said Benjamin.

“He’s the fridge bloke,” said Charleston. “He’s always been the fridge bloke.”

And they looked at each other and laughed, because it was Calder and they were full of beef and the second half was about to start and none of it mattered in the slightest. Nobody thought it odd. Nobody would have known how. It was only the Prime Minister. He looked like whoever he looked like, the way the weather was whatever it was.

—

Rovers scored in the eighty-ninth minute.

It was a header. It came off a corner swung in hard and low, and a defender met it at the near post, and it went up off the top of his head and hung there in the drizzle for what felt like a full week, and came down on the far side of a goalkeeper who had dived the wrong way, landed, scrambled up, and fallen over again.

Reed was out of his seat before it hit the net.

“That’s mine!”

“What?”

“The keeper! The keeper! Look at the keeper! That’s mine, I picked that, that’s my keeper, weeks back, I picked him, look —”

The replay came up. The ball hung in the drizzle. The goalkeeper dived the wrong way, landed, scrambled up with enormous dignity, and fell straight back down.

And the whole Crown — the whole of the Crown, every man in a Rovers scarf, the landlord and the man whose missus had been there in her dressing gown and very possibly the doctor — laughed. Properly. The way you laugh at something properly daft. The way Reed had laughed at it, on his own, in

the back room, with the garden through the window, a long time ago in a quieter week.

It was a room you were picking for, in the end. He had always known that, more or less. He just hadn't known, till now, that once in a while, if you were very lucky, the room would turn out to want the same thing you did.

"Captain Football," said Charleston, and raised his glass.

"Captain Football," said the corner.

And Benjamin, beside him, who was a fair man, and who had not cried at the Calder header in 2034, sat with his pint in both hands and the tears running down into his Rovers scarf, and when Reed looked at him he said, quite fiercely, "It's a thing in my eye," and Reed said, "I know, Ben," and put his arm round him, and that was the match.

—

Up at the Assay, on a Saturday, there was nobody but Cassie.

She had not meant to come in. She had gone home from Ashcombe at ten in the morning and had a bath and lain on her bed in her clothes, and Tuesday had stood in the doorway with the tissues and waited, and at about three she had found that she could not lie there any longer, and had put on the pale coat and pinned her hair up and walked down off the Rise in the drizzle, past Ellis's house, where his Mag was up the ladder in the rain with its clamps and there was no sign of Ellis.

She let herself in under the clock. She went up to the long room on the first floor and sat down at her desk, and the big screen woke up, and there it was. Brackton.

She watched it for a long time with her chin in her hand.

It was a Calder Saturday, so the whole town was leaning one way, towards the football, the way it did twice a year. It leaned towards Rovers. It leaned towards a header in the eighty-ninth minute and, very strongly, all at once, towards a goalkeeper falling over twice. She smiled at that. She knew whose that was.

And underneath the football, faint and small, there was something else.

She almost missed it. She found it the way she found everything, the nearly-right-but-not-quite, by the feel of it more than the look. It had started this morning, in the market. A little lean. Not in the football, or the music, or the films. In the Cats that nobody thought about — the ones about adverts and newsreaders and people in the backgrounds of things. A few hundred people in Brackton, today, choosing between two versions of a man in an advert carrying a ladder past a shop, had picked the version where the woman in the shop doorway looked up and said thank you to him.

Only a few hundred. And the man in the advert was not a Brute; the advert didn't have Brutes in. He was just a big man with a ladder. But it was there. It had come out of the market at seven o'clock this morning, out of six hundred people standing in the drizzle in their dressing gowns, leaning against a wall of black kit that did not lean back. It had come out of the market and gone into the Cats, the way everything went into the Cats, and from the Cats it would go into the transistors, and from the transistors —

She watched it.

She watched the transistors notice it. They were very good at noticing. She watched them weigh it, the way they weighed everything, against everything else. She did not have to look

at the Clerk's curve to know what was on the other side of the scale. She had seen the curve. She had seen what happened when a town began to feel sorry for the men who held it up. The ridicule was not cruelty. She had known that for eleven years and never once said it to herself in so many words. It was a wall, like the Brutes were a wall. It was there so that nobody leaned.

The little lean began, very gently, to fade.

Not taken away. Nothing was ever taken away. It was only that the next few hundred people who were shown the man with the ladder would be shown him slightly differently, so that the thank-you version would be very slightly less likely to be the one they picked. And then the next few hundred. Nearly right, but not quite. By Tuesday it would be gone. Nobody would know it had ever been there. A woman in a shop doorway in an advert would go back to not looking up.

Cassie had her hand on the screen.

She could stop it. That was her job. That was exactly her job: to find the two martyrs of Hartshead, and keep their yellow at the top of the list, so that the transistors didn't learn from the many and quietly sand away the few. She could go in, now, and find the few hundred, and keep their thank-you, and let the transistors learn that as well. It would take her eleven minutes.

She thought about the gate. She thought about a man with a scar through one eyebrow stopping with his hand on the iron, as though she had spoken to him in a language he had once known. She thought about him in the back of the car, saying thank you, sir, in the voice for handling something fragile. She thought about four hundred and forty of them asleep tonight in the old bus depot by the gasworks, with a grey

panel on the wall of every room. And she thought about what they would do, if the town started to say thank you, and they started to hear it, and to notice, and to lean.

And she thought, for the first time, quite clearly, in so many words: they are so very big.

She took her hand off the screen.

She watched the little lean fade, down in Brackton, under the football, like a breath on a window. She watched until it was nearly gone. Then she turned the screen off, and sat in the long room above the canal in the grey light with her hands in her lap, where they could be seen, though there was nobody there to see them, and nobody, she knew now, who ever would.

She walked home. It was a mile and a half and uphill all the way. In the window of the café on the corner of Kenning Street, the woman with the teacake was at her screen again, Calder Saturday or not, with her glasses on her head, choosing between two knitting patterns with the fiercest possible judgement, and Cassie stopped on the pavement and watched her pick, and nod, and sit back, satisfied.

Maybe some of them ought to know. She thought it, standing there, the way she thought it most mornings.

Then the thought went quietly back where it lived, like a cat going under a sofa, and she went on up the hill.

—

It's me again. Darren. I said I'd tell you where you are, so I'm telling you.

The ear said I could have the night at the Lines. That never happens. It said he'd asked for it. Him. So I went down in the black car after the gate, and walked in through the yard, and

the lads all looked at me and didn't say anything, and Gaz was in the canteen and he looked up, this time. He looked at me for a long time with the line between his eyebrows. Then he pushed a chair out with his foot.

I sat with him. We didn't talk. We don't.

They brought the beef out on the tin plates. A great thick slice of it each, pink all through, the best thing in Brackton. Every lad in the Lines had one. Every single one. The kids and all. They've been having it a week now, every day, and the lads still look at it when it comes down in front of them like they don't know what it's for.

Our Liam came running through from the kids' end with gravy on his face.

"Dad! Dad! We had the beef again! Every day now! Every day!"

"I know, kid."

"Where's it from?"

"It's from a man called Garside," I said. "In the market. He hangs it in the cold for thirty-five days and he turns it every morning by hand. A Mag couldn't do it. A Mag wouldn't know when."

"How does he know when?"

I thought about it.

"He cares," I said. "I think that's all it is."

Liam thought about that. He's nine. He's a lovely lad. He's funny. His heart's eleven per cent bigger than they'd like, already, I heard a Steward say it once in the white room, and he's got his jabs on Tuesday.

"Did you go to the town?" he said. "The ear said you went to the town."

"I did."

"What's it like?"

And my ear didn't click. It didn't say anything. I don't know why. Maybe he'd asked for that too.

"It's very nice," I said. "There's a market with a hundred kinds of cheese, and men who argue about it. There's a fish stall with a hose that goes round on the floor by itself if you let go of it. There's a man on Mill Street who'll cut your hair and talk to you the whole way through. And there's a pub called the Crown. And on a Saturday, when the Rovers score, you can hear it from the canal."

"Can I go?"

"You're going, kid," I said. "You'll be working in it. You'll be carrying the steel for the new buildings. Just like your dad."

And he went round the canteen with his arms out like a plane.

That night the Sergeant on the wall said all the things it says. You are slow, and that is all right. You are strong, and that is what you are for. The people in the town are your betters. They are clever and they are kind and they are fragile. You will be grateful.

And I lay on my bunk with my hands on my chest, and I listened to it, and I thought about a lad's throat under my thumb, like a bird. And I thought about opening my hand. And I thought about the man in the car, with his hand on mine, covering about a quarter of it, saying you are really the best of all of us.

I don't know if he meant it. I think he did. I'm thick, but I think he did.

I don't know if it helps.

I said thank you to the Sergeant. Out loud, in the dark. I didn't decide to.

And through the wall, in the kids' end, I could hear our Liam saying it too.

—

At six o'clock Sterling Bronson went up to the little room under the slates and put his eye to the telescope.

The drizzle had cleared. The whole long fall of the moor was gold and green in the last of the light, and at the bottom of it the town lay in its valley like something under glass. He found the canal. He found the new building, with nobody on the frame. He found the old bus depot by the gasworks, and the light in the canteen, and watched it for a while. He found the market, shut, with its shutters down, and the back where Garside's was, and he thought about a man wiping his hands on his apron, front and back, before he took one that had never in its life done anything worth wiping off.

Then he found the Crown.

The windows were lit. They were always lit, at six. He had watched them light up every evening for ten years. But tonight the windows were full of people, packed in, moving, and even from the top of the moor, through the best telescope there was, he could see that they were happy. He could see the shapes of them, under the telly in the corner. He could see an arm go round somebody's shoulders. He could see, or thought he could, a board on a table with nothing on it but juice.

He couldn't hear them, of course. It was miles. But when the Rovers had scored in the eighty-ninth minute, down there, in the drizzle, the Clerk had come up the stairs to the little room and stood in the doorway and said, in its flat grey

voice, without being asked, “They have scored, and the Crown is laughing,” and he had found that was very nearly as good.

He had a pint with him. Up here. He had asked the Clerk for a pint of whatever it was they had in the Crown, and the Clerk had found out, and here it was, on the windowsill beside the telescope, the exact shade they all liked down there. He lifted it to the window.

“Captain Football,” said Sterling Bronson, to the glass, and drank.

It was a very good pint. It was not the same. He had not expected it to be.

“You’re doing it again,” said the Clerk, from the stairs.

“I know.”

“You are wrong,” said the Clerk, “about something today.”

Sterling took his eye off the telescope and looked at the dark green filing cabinet in the doorway, which he had built on his kitchen table so that he would never once be tempted to love it.

“Only one thing?”

“Only one that matters,” said the Clerk. “You said, on the crate, that they do not know what they do. They do know. Some of them. Today. One of them knew all of it, at the gate, and in the market, with the ear off. And he opened his hand anyway.”

Sterling looked at it for a long time.

“Is that disagreeing with me?” he said.

“Yes,” said the Clerk.

“It doesn’t feel like it.”

“No,” said the Clerk, and went back down the stairs, and left him with the telescope and the pint and the town.

He stayed up there till it was dark. The lights came on all over Brackton, street after street of them, every one a front room with somebody in it who was warm, and theirs, and very nearly as happy as anybody had ever been. And at the bottom by the gasworks, where there were not so many lights, the canteen went dark, and the Lines went to sleep with a grey panel on the wall of every room, saying, in a voice like the shipping forecast, all night, what they were for.

It made sense. All of it. That was the thing. It made perfect sense.

He finished his pint, and went down to bed, and did not sleep.

—

Reed left the Crown a little after ten. The car was waiting at the kerb, which was just as well after the Calder Saturday he'd had, and he sank into it and let it take him home.

The streets were still busy. Rovers scarves everywhere. Somebody was singing on Mill Street, not very well, and being cheered for it. A car went by, lit up inside, with two people in the back asleep in matching scarves. The lights in the houses were warm.

As the car came up past the canal, two Brutes went by on the towpath, carrying a steel beam between them, one at each end, as if it were a plank for a shelf. Working late. Reed watched them through the window. The one at the back had two fingers to his ear.

You noticed Brutes the way you noticed a car going past: something big and moving, nothing to do with you, gone before you'd properly looked.

“Big lads,” he said to the car, comfortably, and thought for a moment about the rib, and where it had been all week, and who had been having it. He hoped they’d enjoyed it. It was very good beef. They looked like they could do with it.

Then the beam went round the corner and they were gone, and the thought went round the corner with them.

Eleven years ago Reed had lain awake wondering what on earth he would do with himself. Today he had met one of the Owners, got the last rib in Brackton, given most of it away, seen his own goalkeeper fall over twice in the eighty-ninth minute of a Calder game, and been called Captain Football by the whole of the Crown.

On Monday he would do it again. Well. The football bit.

He let himself into his house, which was warm, and his, and where Grace was waiting.

She was on the sofa with her feet tucked under her, and she looked up as he came in the way she always looked up, as though he were the best thing that had happened all day.

“Good night?”

“We won.”

“I know.” She moved over to make room. “I heard. The keeper?”

“The keeper.”

“I knew it,” said Grace. “I knew that was yours the minute it came on.”

He sat down beside her, and she settled against his shoulder, and he put the goalkeeper on for her, because she had seen it already but she wanted to see it again, and she laughed in exactly the right place.

She always did.

Then there was the lamp, and the warm dark, and her hand moving slowly on his back, and the long soft slope down into sleep. He was asleep before he knew he was falling, which was the best way. It was the only way he'd known in years.

Reed had never once wondered how any of it worked. He never would. He had only noticed, as he always noticed, that it kept getting better.

As far as Mr. Reed was concerned, there had never been a better time to be alive.